BATTLETECH™

ALPHA STRIKE™



QUICK-START RULES

CATALYST game labs™

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Dedication

To everyone that pushed *Alpha Strike* to this point. From an idea to notes to a chapter to a book and finally a boxed game. Ray, Randall, Herb, CamoSpecs, the Catalyst Demo Team, the Master Unit List team, the streamers making videos and podcasts and all the players that kept asking for more *Alpha Strike*. Enjoy, and fire everything you've got!

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Printed in China.
Third Printing

Published by Catalyst Game Labs,
an imprint of InMediaRes Productions, LLC.
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Tacoma, Washington 98407

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And special thanks to the Wolfnet Radio Podcast:
Aaron Krull, Andrew Krull, Charles Gideon, Matthew Behrens, and Thomas Kruger

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ALPHA STRIKE BASICS

It is a universe at war. Even as humankind reached out to command the stars, the human lust for conflict and conquest could not be overcome as easily as the distances of light years. Driven by the dream of one day ruling all of humanity, mighty empires formed, fell, and rose again. From the chaos of war arose the Star League, the pinnacle of human civilization, a Golden Age where a lasting peace and time of prosperity seemed possible at last. But greed, ambition, and treachery combined to tear it all down once more, plunging all the worlds humans called home into centuries of simmering conflict.

Power over trillions rests in the hands of those who can claim noble blood, or the heritage of elite warriors. Generations of warriors have done battle across countless worlds, fighting for a dream long dead, perpetuating the cycle until few could imagine any other way. The most elite among these warriors—like modern-day knights in the neo-feudal realms that now hold sway—are the MechWarriors, those who command the mightiest war machines of the thirty-second century: BattleMechs.

The* BattleTech *universe is a realm of perpetual war between interstellar dynasties and feuding Clans. It is a realm where humankind's greatest enemy is itself, rather than alien invaders. It is a universe where flags and governments change with regularity on the border worlds, and high-minded ideals like "honor", "glory", and "freedom" are the catchphrases of warlords.

It is a universe where life is cheap, but BattleMechs aren't.

Alpha Strike is a fast-playing game of armored combat set in the *BattleTech* universe, where ongoing warfare and neo-feudalism are the norm. In this future, the pinnacle of human technology is the BattleMech, a hulking, robotic war machine weighing up to 100 metric tons, and bristling with weapons and armor. Piloting these BattleMechs are MechWarriors, the elite warriors of the Great House and Clan armies alike. While the battlefield is also home to the vast gamut of infantry, combat vehicles, and aerospace fighters, the BattleMech reigns supreme, and is the focus of this box.

With the *Alpha Strike* rules, players simulate battles between armies with miniatures representing the various battlefield units, and model terrain representing the battlefield itself. Statistical data for each battlefield element is tracked using unit cards, measuring the element's mobility, armor, firepower, and special abilities. Dice are used to resolve attacks between elements, with successful attacks delivering damage that degrades each 'Mech's performance.

The winner of an *Alpha Strike* scenario is often the player whose army is the last one standing, but—as in real life—tactics and mission objectives can evolve beyond even that simple definition of success.

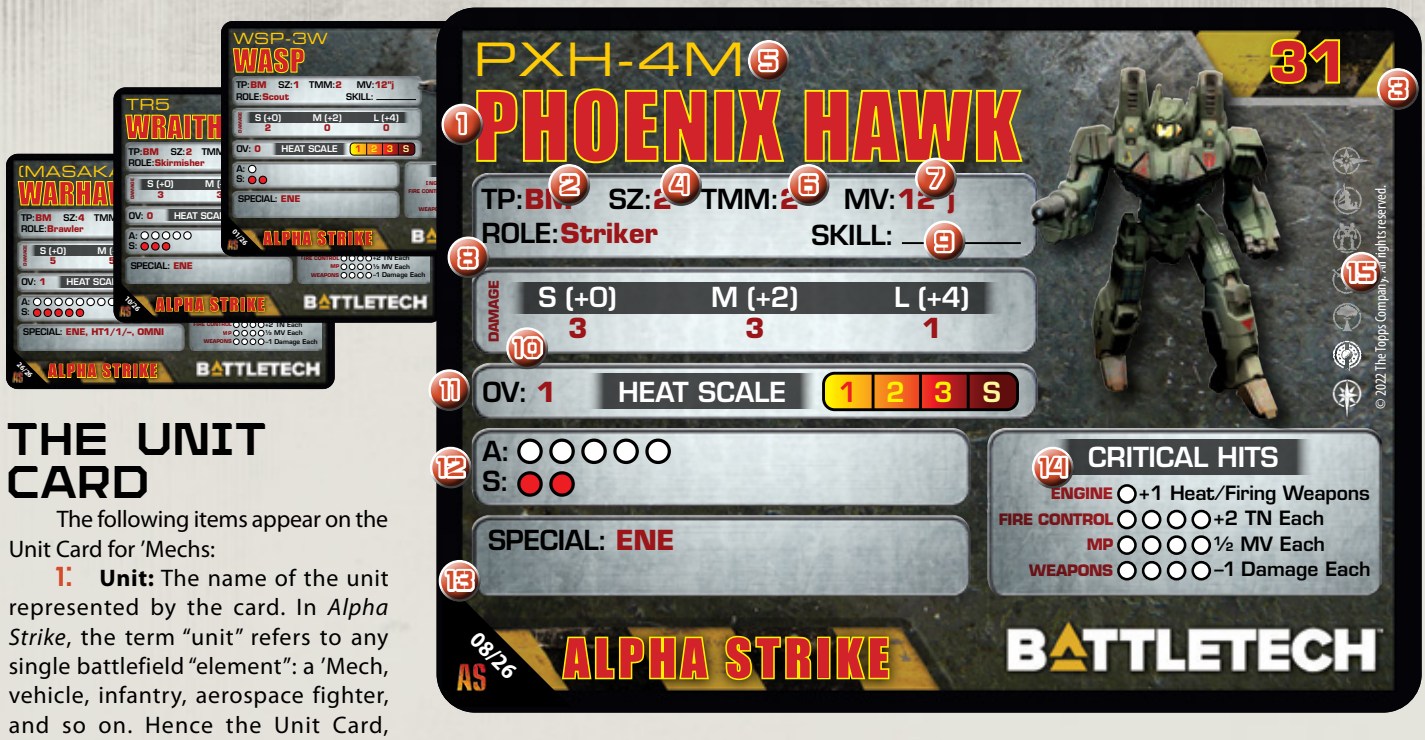
The following Quick-Start Rules (QSR) are designed to familiarize new players with the basics of the *Alpha Strike* game system. As such, they focus entirely on ground warfare between BattleMechs ('Mechs), as they are the primary (and most flexible) of *BattleTech*'s combat units.

COMPONENTS

Your *BattleTech: Alpha Strike* boxed set includes:

- **Plastic Miniatures:** Thirteen high-quality plastic miniatures, which are ready to play without any cutting or assembly required. The miniatures represent some of the most common BattleMechs found among Inner Sphere and Clan forces.
- **MechWarrior Cards:** Twenty-six MechWarriors on thirteen cards detail the elite warriors of the Inner Sphere and the Clans, along with the Special Pilot Abilities they bring to any battlefield.
- ***BattleTech: Alpha Strike* Quick-Start Rules:** This is the rulebook you're currently reading.
- ***BattleTech* Primer:** This pamphlet introduces *BattleTech*'s incredibly rich fictional setting, through the ilClan era.
- **Buildings:** Fold-up cardboard buildings, including nine small- and six medium-sized buildings.
- **Punchboards:** These contain punch-outs with terrain templates and essential tokens for gameplay.
- **Tables Card:** This card compiles tables found in this rules booklet, to be used for ease of reference during game play.
- **Dice:** *Alpha Strike* is played using two six-sided dice.
- ***Alpha Strike* Unit Cards:** These cards provide the game stats and damage tracking for the BattleMechs included. They are laminated for dry erase marker use.





THE UNIT CARD

The following items appear on the Unit Card for 'Mechs:

1: Unit: The name of the unit represented by the card. In *Alpha Strike*, the term "unit" refers to any single battlefield "element": a 'Mech, vehicle, infantry, aerospace fighter, and so on. Hence the Unit Card, where this page will use "unit" in describing the various parts of the card. Since there are only 'Mechs in this box, anytime the word "unit" may be referenced, it is referring to a 'Mech; and for clarity, after this page the rules usually reference 'Mech.

2: Type (TP): The Type field on a unit card indicates the general classification of a unit in two-letter codes. The BattleMech (BM) is the only unit type covered in *Alpha Strike* Quick-Start Rules.

3: Point Value (PV): A unit's Point Value measures its approximate battlefield strength, based on its combat capabilities.

4: Size (SZ): On the unit card, the unit's Size is a numerical value indicating its weight class. BattleMechs tend to come in four Sizes, in increasing weight: 1 (Light), 2 (Medium), 3 (Heavy), and 4 (Assault).

5: 'Mech Variant/Configuration: Each 'Mech is considered a unique chassis, but each chassis may have several variants and/or configurations available (the art and models usually don't change).

6: TMM: Target Movement Modifier. This is the attack modifier the unit receives if it is the target of an attack while using its standard movement mode. If the unit has received damage that reduces its TMM, uses a different movement mode or temporarily has a lower available TMM due to heat or other effects, its Target Movement Modifier will be different.

7: Movement (Move (MV)): On the unit card, the Move field indicates the number of inches the unit may move during a turn of gameplay. When a letter appears after this number of inches, it indicates a special mode of movement the unit might possess, such as the ability to jump (j).

8: Role: The typical combat role of the unit.

9: Skill: This blank area on the unit card is where the player can indicate the base Target Number for the unit's attacks. (A regular-rated MechWarrior commonly has a value of 4, while a value of 1—or even 0—indicates a legendary-rated MechWarrior.)

10: Damage Value (DV): The numbers shown in this part of the unit card indicates the amount of damage points the unit can deliver at each range bracket, along with the appropriate Target Number modifiers—S (+0), M (+2), and L (+4). These range brackets, respectively, are Short, Medium, and Long. If a unit cannot deliver damage at a range bracket, it may have either a dash ("—") in that bracket, or a "0*" (meaning it can use the *Minimal Damage* rule).

11: Overheat Value (OV) and Heat Scale: The Overheat Value indicates the number of damage points the unit can add to its attack, in exchange for suffering an equal amount of heat. Overheating is tracked in the four boxes to the right of the heat scale, with each point of overheat given its own box. If the unit suffers 4 or more points of overheating, it will shutdown (indicated by the "S" in the fourth box of the Heat Scale).

12: Armor and Structure (A/S): The white bubbles in this part of the unit card indicate how many points of external armor the unit possesses, while the red bubbles track how many points of internal structure it possesses. When a unit is damaged, these bubbles are crossed off. A unit that has had all of its structure bubbles marked off is considered to be destroyed.

13: Special Abilities (Special): In *Alpha Strike*, units that possess special battlefield abilities beyond movement, damage, armor, and structure, will note these as Special Abilities. These features are described on the unit card using abbreviations and are further described later in this book.

14: Critical Hits: The card has several different Critical Hit effects that can be marked to keep track of critical damage.

15: Era Availability: The *BattleTech* universe covers a thousand years, with specifically-named Eras (as seen in the *Primer*) determining the availability of a given 'Mech. The icons highlighted on a Unit Card illustrate the Eras in which this variant is available.

THE INNER SPHERE VS. THE CLANS

The *Alpha Strike* boxed set contains components to create at least two Forces, classified as Inner Sphere and Clan. Even though the Inner Sphere and the Clans are in turn comprised of even more factions, the cultural, historical, and technological divide between the two allow the factions of the *BattleTech* universe to be placed within these two broad categories. In the ilClan era, the lines between the two have begun to blur after a century of interaction. Many Inner Sphere and Clan factions are allies; in fact some have completely merged to become something new altogether. Refer to the *Primer* for more information.

This box contains eight Inner Sphere 'Mechs and five Clan 'Mechs. Clan technology is more advanced, so their 'Mechs tend to pack more punch than their Inner Sphere counterparts. Each miniature is listed below by faction.

The thirteen MechWarrior cards are broken down into eight Inner Sphere and five Clan cards; the front side of eight of the cards detail MechWarriors from the Northwind Highlanders mercenary command, and the front side of the remaining five cards highlight MechWarriors from Clan Jade Falcon. The back sides of the cards feature MechWarriors from various other Inner Sphere and Clan factions.

INNER SPHERE



LOCUST

Weight Class (Size): Light (1)
Role: Scout

Lacking jump-jets and light on armor, a *Locust*'s superior ground speed enables fluid flanking or breakthroughs. If you're bogged down, disengage and redirect.



WASP

Weight Class (Size): Light (1)
Role: Scout

Too lightly armed and armored for stand-up fights, a *Wasp*'s speed and maneuverability make it a perfect scouting 'Mech. Just remember, movement is life.



BLACKJACK

Weight Class (Size): Medium (2)
Role: Brawler or Sniper

Relatively slow for its size, the *Blackjack*'s jump jets keep it mobile, while its paired autocannons bring excellent range. Death by paper cuts!



PHOENIX HAWK

Weight Class (Size): Medium (2)
Role: Striker

The *Phoenix Hawk*'s speed, armor, and armament allow it to function superbly in multiple roles, from scout to striker to skirmisher. Use that flexibility.



WRAITH

Weight Class (Size): Medium (2)
Role: Skirmisher

Incredible speed and maneuverability are the *Wraith*'s hallmarks, though its weaponry is short-ranged–an easy compromise. Strike often.



ARCHER

Weight Class (Size): Heavy (3)
Role: Missile Boat

An unparalleled fire-support 'Mech, the *Archer* mounts a blistering number of long-range missiles, backed by energy weapons. Shoot from range!



WARHAMMER

Weight Class (Size): Heavy (3)
Role: Brawler

The yard-stick for other 'Mechs, the *Warhammer* is a great blend of serious armor and firepower. With good support, it can go toe-to-toe with assault 'Mechs.



ATLAS

Weight Class (Size): Assault (4)
Role: Juggernaut or Sniper

The quintessential assault 'Mech, the *Atlas* doesn't mount as much firepower as some of this class–but it makes up for that with obscene amounts of armor. Use it!



CLAN



FIRE MOTH

Weight Class (Size): Light (1)
Role: Striker

One of the quickest 'Mechs on the field, the *Fire Moth* combines lightning speed with a vicious strike. But it's a one-shot wonder: use judiciously.



POUNCER

Weight Class (Size): Medium (2)
Role: Sniper or Scout

Boasting a great mix of maneuverability and firepower, the *Pouncer* can easily range across the battlefield, bringing its weapons to bear. Keep it moving.



NOVA

Weight Class (Size): Medium (2)
Role: Skirmisher

The *Nova* offers massive strike capability for its medium weight class, but don't get too cocky: it can't survive long against the big boys. But they'll pay.



TIMBER WOLF

Weight Class (Size): Heavy (3)
Role: Brawler or Missile Boat

The *Timber Wolf* is a nearly perfect 'Mech: solid redeployment speeds, enough armor to mix it up, and brilliant firepower. You'll be a target—embrace that.



WARHAWK

Weight Class (Size): Assault (4)
Role: Sniper or Brawler

A showcase of Clan technology that allows for massive firepower at range, the *Warhawk* is a sniper extraordinaire. Set it in place and carve up your opponents!

PREPARE TO PLAY

Preparing to play is setup and choosing any special rules. Setup consists of determining the objectives of the scenario, determining each player's forces, selecting and placing terrain, and choosing starting positions. Specific scenarios will often modify these general setup rules. Two introductory scenarios are included in these rules (see *Scenarios*, pp. 26 and 31), which are suggested to be the first (Meet and Greet) and second (Clash of Steel) games for players new to *Alpha Strike*. After which, using these rules, you can easily build your own scenarios.

Setup: Use the follow steps for setup:

- **1. Determining Objectives**
- **2. Determining Forces**
- **3. Rolling Initiative & Determining Terrain**
- **4. Starting Positions**

1. DETERMINING OBJECTIVES



Select or randomly determine one of the objectives listed below as the objective for the scenario. By default, both players receive the same objective, and each follows the directions for that objective entirely (e.g., both sides place objective tokens as called for). Optionally, each player may instead randomly determine their own, separate objective.

Standard Playing Area: Small scale battles using the *Alpha Strike Box Set* components can fit on a 3' x 4' to 4' x 4' playing area. Larger *Alpha Strike* games can require up to a 4' x 6' playing area. Players deploy along the variable length side, leaving 4' across the table to the other player.

OBJECTIVE RAID

Each player places their three tokens at least 21" from their home edge, with each token at least 18" away from any other of their objective tokens. If a player's 'Mech is in base-to-base contact with one of their objective tokens in the End Phase, it may pick up the objective token. If a 'Mech carrying an objective token is destroyed, place the objective token in place of the destroyed 'Mech. If a player's 'Mech with an objective token is in base-to-base contact with their home edge, the objective token is removed from its possession and returned to the map using the same setup instructions above, and that player scores 2 victory points. If a player has scored 10 points by the End Phase of any turn, the scenario ends, and that player wins the scenario.

CONTROL THE FIELD

Each End Phase in which one or more of a player's 'Mechs is within 12" of their opponent's home edge, that player scores the 'Mech's Size in victory points. Players may score multiple victory points in a turn if they have multiple units within 12" of their opponent's home edge, and at least 12" away from any other 'Mech that they scored with this turn. If a player has scored 12 points by the End Phase of any turn, the scenario ends, and that player wins the scenario.

DESTROY THE ENEMY

Players score 1 victory point per Size rating of an enemy 'Mech that is destroyed or crippled (see p. 12). If a player has scored 10 victory points (12 for the Clan player) by the End Phase of any turn, the scenario ends and that player wins the scenario. If playing Inner Sphere versus Clan, each Clan 'Mech destroyed counts as 1.5 points per its Size rating.

HOLD THE FORT

Each player places two of their objective tokens at least 12" from their home edge, with each token at least 18" away from any other of their objective tokens. Starting on the End Phase of Turn 3, if no enemy 'Mech is within 12" of your objective token during the End Phase, and at least one of a player's 'Mechs is within 6" of their objective token, that player scores a victory point. Players can score for both of their objective tokens each End Phase, for a maximum of 2 victory points per turn. If a player has scored 10 victory points by the End Phase of any turn, the scenario ends, and that player wins the scenario.

BREAKTHROUGH

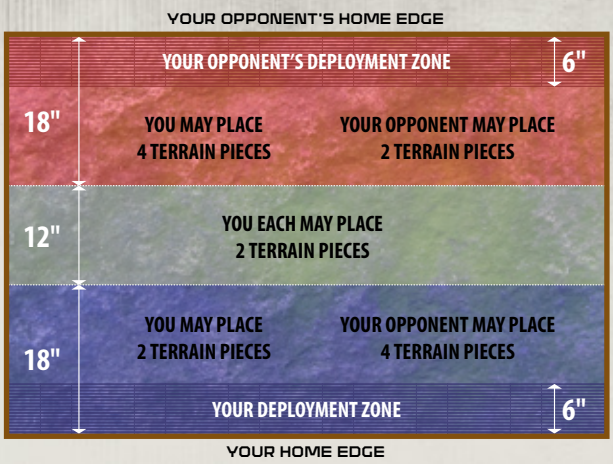
If a player's 'Mech is in base-to-base contact with their opponent's home edge during the End Phase of a turn, remove the 'Mech from the game and score its Size in victory points. If a player has scored 10 victory points by the End Phase of any turn, the scenario ends, and that player wins the scenario. If playing Inner Sphere versus Clan, each Clan 'Mech counts as 1.5 points per its Size rating toward victory points.

FIND THE TARGET

Each player places three objective tokens on buildings at least 21" from their home edge, and at least 18" away from any of their other objective tokens. If a player's 'Mech is within 6" of one of their objective tokens in the End Phase, it may scan for the target. Roll 2D6; on a 7+ the building bearing that token is a target; on a 6 or less, the token is not detected, but it can be scanned by other 'Mechs within 6", or on subsequent turns. That player may now attack the target in future Combat Phases. The target is immobile and can take 10 damage before being destroyed. Players score 5 victory points in the End Phase for each target building they destroyed that turn, and reposition that objective token following the same setup rules as before. If any player has scored 10 victory points by the End Phase of any turn, the scenario ends, and that player wins the scenario.

2. DETERMINING FORCES

Each player receives 250 Point Value (PV) to select 'Mechs for their force. The Alpha Strike Unit Cards list the PV for the 'Mech at the default Skill rating of 4. For additional options when building a force, including modifying Skill ratings, see *Force Building*, page 33.



• Your Terrain Setup Diagram •

3. Rolling Initiative & Determining Terrain

Terrain in *Alpha Strike* can affect movement and combat and serve as objectives. The amount of terrain placed on a battlefield can greatly affect the speed of play and feel of a battle.

Each player's home edge is the long side of the playing area at opposite sides from the other player. Players roll 2D6, with the highest result the Initiative winner. Next, each player selects eight pieces of terrain, which may be buildings, hills, woods, water, and so on. The Initiative winner places one piece of terrain first and players alternate placing one piece of terrain until all terrain has been placed. Each player may place four terrain pieces between 6" and 24" from the center line of the play area toward their opponent's home edge, two from 6"–24" from the center line toward their own home edge, and two within 6" of the center line of the play area.

Terrain Types

Each type of terrain used in *Alpha Strike* is listed below, along with a summary of how the terrain is depicted in the game and how the terrain affects movement, line of sight and attacks.

Movement: Most terrain impedes movement, adding an additional movement cost per inch moved through that terrain. Some terrain is prohibited; 'Mechs may not move into or through prohibited terrain (see *Movement Phase*, p. 14).

Creating Your Own Woods Template

Players may accentuate the trees from this box by creating a template in any shape desired, made of felt, paper or other material. A flat template is placed on the play area to represent the woods area, and one or more singular trees (the sets of trees in this box share the same coloring and rough dimensions) are then placed within the woods template. The template should be 4" to 6" in diameter. If the template is narrow in one dimension (2" to 4"), then it can be longer (8" to 10"). A woods template exceeding these dimensions counts as two terrain choices.

The entire area of the woods template is covered by woods with the singular tree(s) providing a nice visual representation. Trees on a separate template should be moved as needed to allow movement through the template, or to check line of sight. Trees which define a woods area by their placement should not be moved, and 'Mechs may not end their movement on the trees.

For added realism, many modeling companies make and sell miniature trees, which you would exchange for the cardboard trees from this box. Z scale or micro armor scale fits *Alpha Strike* scale most appropriately.

Line of Sight: Some terrain will block line of sight that passes through the terrain (see *Verify Line of Sight*, p. 17). To block line of sight or apply an attack modifier (see below), the terrain must have a height, and at least two-thirds of the target must be obscured by the terrain.

Attack Modifier: Some terrain will make an attack more difficult if the line of sight goes through, or the target occupies, the terrain (see *Combat Phase*, p. 17).

Clear

Any part of the play area without any terrain placed upon it is clear terrain. It has the default movement cost (1" to move one inch) and does not block line of sight or have an attack modifier.

Woods, Single Tree

A singular tree, such as those from this box, exist by itself, and count as a lone instance of woods. Singular woods are typically 2" tall with a 2" diameter but can vary from 1" to 4" tall and 1" to 3"







diameter. A player selecting singular trees can select two trees as a single terrain choice.

Movement: 'Mechs cannot end their movement within singular woods. Players should not move the singular Woods to allow movement or for other gameplay purposes. 'Mechs may move through the tree by paying the additional Woods movement cost (+1").

Line of Sight: A single tree by itself does not block line of sight but counts as 2" of woods (see *Woods, Template* below).

Attack Modifier: If the line of sight for an attack passes through woods, the attack receives the woods modifier. A target 'Mech in base-to-base contact with the woods is occupying the woods and also receives the woods modifier when attacked.

WOODS, TEMPLATE

Template woods represent a larger forest. The template represents an area of woods, with representative trees to reference for line of sight determinations. Placing two or more singular trees within 6" of each other can create and define a template. Two trees creates a line template, while three trees creates a triangle template, and four a rectangle, either of which count as a single terrain choice.

Movement: 'Mechs can move through or end their movement in woods templates. They pay the additional movement cost of the woods while moving through the template (see *Movement Phase*, p. 14).

Line of Sight: Line of sight is blocked by 6" or more of Woods along the line of sight.

Attack Modifier: If the line of sight for an attack passes through woods, the woods are intervening and the attack receives the woods attack modifier. If a target 'Mech's base overlaps at least part of the woods template, it is occupying the woods and receives the woods modifier when attacked. The attack only receives the woods modifier once, even if the woods are both intervening and occupied by the target.

HILLS

Hills are measured by their level (i.e. elevation), determined by how high they are above the base ground level of the play area. Hills should be created in increments of 1 inch. A hill template should be 4" to 6" in diameter. If the template is narrow in one dimension (2" to 4"), then it can be longer (8" to 10"). Larger templates count as two terrain choices.

Other terrain can be placed on top of hills, as long as the template for that terrain fits within a single level of the hill. This includes placing a second (or third or fourth) hill on top of the first, creating higher hills. Larger templates can include a smaller hill template as a second level as part of the two terrain choices used for the larger template; for example, a large hill template with a small second level would still count as only two terrain choices (not three).

Movement: Moving across the top of a hill does not cost any additional movement. Moving up and down the hill, as in moving from ground level up 1" onto a hill, is a level change and costs additional movement for each 1" of level up or down. A 'Mech may not cross more than 2" of level change within 2" of horizontal movement across. A 3" or greater level change within 2" of horizontal movement is prohibited terrain.

Line of Sight: Line of sight is blocked by a hill if more than two-thirds of the target is behind the hill.

Attack Modifier: If the line of sight is blocked for more than one third, but less than two-thirds of the target, the target has partial cover (see *Partial Cover Modifier*, p. 19).

CREATING YOUR OWN HILLS

Layers of cardboard or foam boards, cut into roughly circle or oval shapes work well for *Alpha Strike* hills, showing a clear level change and providing plenty of surface on which to stand the miniatures. The cardboard or foam board can then be painted and/or flocked, and additional layers added to make taller hills. Increments of 1" or multiples of 1" level changes work particularly well for *Alpha Strike*.

Other materials can also be used to create levels, such as small boxes covered in green or brown felt, or a book under a cloth. If the hill has particularly steep or slippery slopes, players should give each other the benefit of the doubt and not require a miniature to stand in a precarious position. A miniature can be placed firmly on a flat surface near the top or bottom of the hill, and an objective marker or other token used to show its actual position and facing on the hill. Remember that a 'Mech cannot climb or descend more than 2" within a 2" horizontal movement; if the slope is steeper than 2" level over 2" across, the 'Mech cannot climb that hill.



BUILDINGS

Buildings in *Alpha Strike* are measured by their level, their template area, and their structural strength (see *Buildings*, p. 28).

Buildings can be 1" to 12" in elevation, with most being 1" to 3" tall and each inch of level representing one or two stories. The *Alpha Strike* box comes with 9 smaller buildings (approximately 1.6" square) and 6 larger buildings (approximately 4.25" x 3"). Two small buildings or one larger building count as a single terrain choice.

Buildings are divided into four broad categories that define both their structural strength and overall size in *Alpha Strike*: Light, Medium, Heavy, and Hardened. Each of these building types is further described by its construction factor (CF), a value that approximates how much damage the building can sustain before it is reduced to rubble. The *Alpha Strike* box set comes with two types of buildings. By default, the smaller buildings are Medium, while the larger are Heavy. However, players are free to modify those values as they see fit for a given scenario.

Movement: Buildings cost additional movement to move through, depending on their structural category. In these Quick-Start Rules, 'Mechs may not end their movement in a building, but they may move through, jump on to them (as long as the building level is less than or equal to the jump movement of the 'Mech) or move on top of buildings (as long as the level change to reach the top of the building is 2" or less).

Line of Sight: Buildings block line of sight using the same rules as Hills (see p. 9).

Attack Modifiers: Buildings can provide partial cover using the same rules as Hills (see p. 9).

Other rules: Buildings can be attacked and destroyed. Moving through a building will also damage it. Such damage, along with exceeding the weight capacity of a building, can cause it to collapse (see p. 28).

Other types of buildings: Bridges, walls and other constructions use the same rules as buildings.


BUILDINGS

CREATING YOUR OWN BUILDINGS

Papercraft buildings can be downloaded from several online sources—including from bg.battletech.com/downloads—printed and folded to create 3D structures. Players can also use small containers or cut-down containers such as plastic bottles and cardboard cartons to make buildings.

If purchasing model buildings or 3D printing plastic buildings, note the sizes listed for the structure. Many 25mm or larger-scale buildings will be oversized for *Alpha Strike* and dwarf the 'Mechs beside them, when that type of building should be smaller than a 'Mech—a 25mm cottage will look like a skyscraper-sized monster on an *Alpha Strike* battlefield. Z scale or micro armor scale fits *Alpha Strike* scale most appropriately.

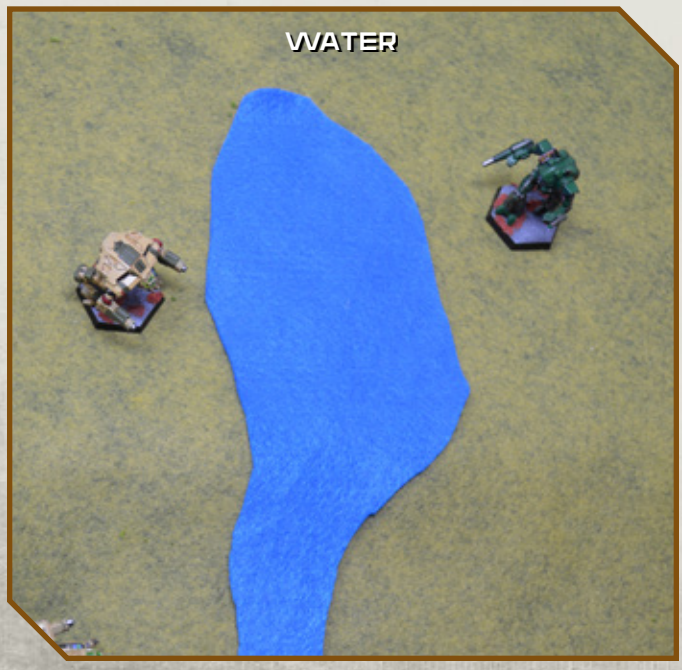
WATER

Water features are measured by their depth (negative elevation); how low they are below the base ground level of the play area. In these Quick-Start Rules, water is limited to a 1" Depth. The water template should be 4" to 6" in diameter. If the template is narrow in one dimension (2" to 3"), then it can be longer (8" to 12"). Water templates exceeding these dimensions counts as two terrain choices.

Movement: Movement through water costs additional movement, and descending from ground level to the water depth is a level change (see *Hills*, p. 9). For example, entering Depth 1" water from clear ground requires first paying the level change of 1", and then each inch of movement through water incurs the additional water movement cost. Leaving the water then requires paying for another level change.

Line of Sight: Line of sight is not blocked by Depth 1" water.

Attack Modifier: 'Mechs in water have partial cover (see *Partial Cover Modifier*, p. 19).


WATER

CREATING YOUR OWN WATER TEMPLATES

Water templates can be constructed from a variety of materials, from simple blue felt or cardstock cut into river or lake shapes, to more complex projects such as clear acrylic within a riverbank mold.

CREATING YOUR OWN ROUGH TEMPLATES

Rough templates can be constructed from a variety of materials, such as gray felt, cardstock, or paper cut into rough field shapes; you can add flocking or pebbles, as desired. You can also create small rough markers by taking a basing material, or even an extra hex base, and flocking it with pebbles or sand.

ROUGH/RUBBLE

Rough terrain can be loose rocks, construction debris, or other materials scattered in an area where a 'Mech must show some caution in crossing. Rough terrain is usually represented by templates 2" to 6" in diameter. Two smaller templates (2") can be selected as a single terrain choice, or one larger (4" to 6") template counts as one terrain choice.

Rubble uses the same rules as rough terrain; the primary difference is that rubble terrain is not placed during setup, it is created when buildings are destroyed. Rubble terrain is usually represented by a template that matches that shape of the building that was destroyed.

Players may also use small rough markers to form a template similar to trees. Rough markers placed within 4" of each other form a template between them of rough terrain. Two rough markers within 4" of each other creates a "line" template of rough terrain, while three would form a triangle template, and four rough markers within 4" of each creates a square template.

Movement: Movement across rough or rubble terrain adds an additional 1" movement cost per inch moved across rough terrain.

Line of Sight: Rough and rubble terrain do not affect line of sight.

Attack Modifier: Rough and rubble terrain do not impose attack modifiers.



4. STARTING POSITIONS

Generally, 'Mechs begin play off the battlefield, and enter the battlefield during the first turn. If the players agree, 'Mechs may instead begin play already on their battlefields within their deployment zones (defined as the whole map area, within 6 inches of the 'Mechs' home edge; see diagram on page 8).

In this latter case, the player who made the higher Initiative roll during set-up may choose whether to begin setting up their 'Mechs first or second. Once this is decided, each player takes turns placing one of their 'Mechs on the map within their force's deployment zone until all 'Mechs have been placed. 'Mechs may be placed with any facing desired.



TERRAIN SCALE

BattleMechs are roughly 7 meters to 16 meters tall, and the miniatures 2" tall on average. This works out to 1" = 6 meters. Micro armor scale, aka 1/285th or 6 mm, works well with *Alpha Strike*. Anything between 1/300th and 1/250th, including Z scale models and terrain, should work as well.

Terrain in other scales can be used with *Alpha Strike* but players should be aware that they may need to reconsider what such terrain is representing. A small, single-story house in N scale would be several stories tall and four times the floor area at *Alpha Strike* scale, and might better represent an office complex. Larger scale hills can often work, with the awareness that more than 2" of level change over 2" horizontal movement remains prohibited to 'Mechs.

SPECIAL RULES

Now that you've finished setup, there are a number of optional rules that can be used to change the *Alpha Strike* experience or enhance scenario replays. These should be chosen before the game begins and agreed upon by all players. It is recommended that players not employ these rules for their first *Alpha Strike* games, and add them once the basics of gameplay are understood.

BATTLEFIELD SUPPORT

Battlefield Support gives players the options to bring abstract artillery and aerospace support for their 'Mechs (see p. 29). Players may choose to use 0, 5 or 12 Battlefield Support Points (BSPs) for these scenarios or roll 1D6: 1–2 grants 0 BSP per player, 3–4 grants 5 BSP per player, 5–6 grants 12 BSP per player.

FORCED WITHDRAWAL

Forces will not usually fight to the last warrior. Instead, once they have taken substantial amounts of damage, they will begin to retreat. The Forced Withdrawal rules help simulate this situation.

Under Forced Withdrawal, 'Mechs must retreat from the battlefield when crippled (see below). A 'Mech subject to Forced Withdrawal must always move toward its home map edge. However, the 'Mech need not take a Sprinting Move. Withdrawing 'Mechs may still attack an enemy 'Mech that enters within range of a weapon or physical attack.

CRIPPLED

A 'Mech is considered crippled under any of the following conditions:

- The 'Mech has no Armor remaining and has been reduced to half its starting Structure value (rounded up).
- The 'Mech has been reduced to a damage value of 0 for all Medium- and Long-range attacks.
- The 'Mech has been immobilized through critical hit effects.

Unless specifically stated otherwise, if a 'Mech exits the play area for any reason, it is considered destroyed and may not re-enter the scenario.

FORMATIONS

Force Building rules (see pp. 33–39) have requirements for various specializations of training and tactics for small Formations (Lances or Stars) that give bonus abilities to the members of those Formations.

MECHWARRIOR CARDS

These cards bring notable MechWarriors from the fiction to life. Review the MechWarrior Cards and consider adding them to your game. Use the following rules when doing so:

- Only one BattleMech per side can have an attached MechWarrior Card.
- Both MechWarrior Cards must have the same cost in Special Pilot Abilities (SPA).

FORCE BALANCE

As noted above, both MechWarrior Cards must have the same SPA cost, so both players will need to agree on that cost prior to the game. If the players cannot agree, they should roll 1D6 and divide by 2 (rounding down).

MECHWARRIOR SKILLS

All MechWarrior Cards include the MechWarrior's Skill rating, at the top left (the number at the top right is the Piloting Skill, which is not used in *Alpha Strike* play). Use the value listed on the card during game play. If players are replaying one of the scenarios from this rulebook, note that the values on the MechWarrior Card will replace the Skill listed in the scenario entry for that 'Mech. However, to maintain force balance, an opposing MechWarrior should have their Skill rating improved (i.e., lowered) by the same increment as the bonus provided by the MechWarrior Card.

For example, if a MechWarrior Card would lower a 'Mech's rating from Skill 3 to Skill 2, an opposing MechWarrior could improve their Skill of 4 by one rating, to Skill 3.



• *Light Bombing* Battlefield Support Card •



• *Rebecca Green* MechWarrior Card •

PLAYING THE GAME

This section provides an overview of the *Alpha Strike* gameplay sequence. For simplicity, these rules presume that each game (a scenario) is made up of two sides, controlled either by two players or by two teams of players. Whenever the rules refer to a player, that term can mean a team of players as well as an individual.

SEQUENCE OF PLAY

An *Alpha Strike* game consists of a series of turns. During each turn, all 'Mechs on the table will have an opportunity to move and fire their weapons or make physical attacks. Each turn consists of several smaller turn segments, called phases. During each phase, players may take one type of action, such as movement or combat.

The players execute the phases in a given order. Specific actions, movement, effects of damage and so on are fully explained in separate sections later in these rules.

Each turn includes the following phases, performed in the following order:

STEP 1: INITIATIVE PHASE

At the start of every turn, including the first, each player rolls 2D6 and adds the results together to determine Initiative; re-roll ties. The player with the higher result wins the Initiative for that turn.

Because movement and combat are considered to occur simultaneously in the course of an *Alpha Strike* game turn, the Initiative winner actually executes 'Mech movement and combat actions after the player(s) with the lower Initiative roll. This simulates a greater awareness of the tactical situation.

STEP 2: MOVEMENT PHASE

The player with the lowest Initiative roll moves one of their 'Mechs first. Presuming an equal number of 'Mechs on the two sides, the Initiative winner then moves one of their 'Mechs, and the players continue alternating their 'Mech movements until all 'Mechs have been moved.

If the number of 'Mechs per side is unequal, the player with the higher number of 'Mechs must move more 'Mechs in proportion to that of their opponent. See the *Unequal Number of 'Mechs* rule (see p. 14) for how to govern that situation.

STEP 3: COMBAT PHASE

As with the movement phase, the player with the lowest Initiative roll acts first in the Combat Phase, but—rather than alternating actions—this player declares and resolves all of their 'Mechs' combat actions at this time, followed by the Initiative winner.

In the Combat Phase, each 'Mech may execute one attack. Damage from these attacks is resolved immediately, but the effects do not take place until the turn's End Phase. This means that a destroyed 'Mech will normally have a chance to return fire.

STEP 4: END PHASE

Both players may complete the End Phase simultaneously.

In this phase, each player executes any miscellaneous actions remaining for the turn, such as applying damage effects and removing destroyed 'Mechs, and applying Heat or Cooling Down. Victory Conditions are checked to determine if the scenario ends. The specific rules for such actions state whether or not they take place during the End Phase.

After resolving all End Phase actions, the turn ends and the players return to Step 1, repeat all these steps until one side meets its victory conditions for the scenario.

VICTORY CONDITIONS

Unless playing a pickup game where victory is achieved when all of one player's 'Mechs are destroyed, victory conditions are determined by the specific scenario and are checked in the End Phase unless specified otherwise.



MOVEMENT PHASE

Every 'Mech has a base Move (MV) listed on its unit card. This value is the maximum number of inches the 'Mech may move during its turn. A 'Mech may move in any direction and—at the end of its movement—may face in any direction. 'Mechs need not move their full amount; in place of moving, a 'Mech may simply stand still. A 'Mech may make multiple turns during the course of its movement to maneuver around obstacles, so long as the inches traveled are within its maximum Move rating. (Using a flexible tape measure, to correctly measure this indirect distance, is highly recommended.)

As previously discussed, terrain may prohibit or impede a 'Mech's movement, as shown on the Movement Cost Table (see p. 15).

MINIMUM MOVEMENT

As long as a 'Mech is mobile (meaning that its Move has not been reduced to zero through damage or heat effects), it can always move 2" in any direction, regardless of the terrain's movement costs (unless the terrain in question is prohibited).

FACING

'Mechs are considered to be facing the same way as the feet of the miniature representing the 'Mech (some adjudication may be required).

A 'Mech's facing affects combat resolution (see *Combat Phase*, p. 17), and can only be voluntarily changed during the Movement Phase.

STACKING

During the Movement Phase, a 'Mech may move through a space occupied by other friendly 'Mechs but may not move through unfriendly 'Mechs at the same level. If the 'Mechs occupy different levels during a 'Mech's movement (such as when a 'Mech with jumping capability uses it to move), the 'Mechs are at different levels and may pass through the same space.

An entire 'Mech's base must fit within any terrain restrictions. For example, if two enemy 'Mechs are 1" from each other, an enemy 'Mech may not move between them, as the 1 1/4" base will not fit between those two enemy 'Mechs. This would break the stacking restrictions above. If there is only 1" between two 3" high level changes, 'Mechs cannot fit between the two at the ground level. This would break the movement rules for level changes and is prohibited terrain. Similarly, a 'Mech must be legally able to cross all terrain its base occupies. A 'Mech can stand on a slope that is 2" high because 'Mechs can move across a level change of 2" per 2" traveled. A 'Mech cannot stand or move through where its base occupies both a 0" level and a 3" level as a 3" level change is prohibited terrain for 'Mechs.

Regardless of how they arrive at their destination, 'Mechs in *Alpha Strike* may not occupy the same space on the game table, regardless of any differences in level.

UNEQUAL NUMBER OF 'MECHS

The Movement Phase requires each player to alternate moving their Force's 'Mechs. In a turn consisting of an equal number of 'Mechs on each side, this simply means that each player takes a turn moving a single 'Mech before their opponent does the same, and so on, until all 'Mechs are moved. But if the numbers of 'Mechs per side are not equal, this procedure must be altered accordingly.

To maintain fairness, unequal numbers of 'Mechs must be moved in proportion. This means that if, prior to any pair of 'Mech movements, one side has twice as many 'Mechs left to move as the other side, the player with twice as many 'Mechs must move two 'Mechs on their side, rather than one. If a side has three times as many 'Mechs as its opponent, it must move three 'Mechs at a time to every one of its opponent's 'Mechs moved, and so forth.

For example, at the beginning of the Movement Phase, Side A has eight 'Mechs and Side B has five 'Mechs. Side A wins Initiative. Before the first pair of movements, Side A does not have double or more the number of 'Mechs Side B has remaining to move, so Side B moves one BattleMech, then Side A moves one BattleMech.

Now, Side A has seven 'Mechs left to move while Side B has four 'Mechs left to move. Since Side A still does not have twice as many 'Mechs left to move, each side again moves one BattleMech. Before the third pair of movements, Side A has six 'Mechs left to move—twice as many as Side B has left to move. This means Side A must now move two 'Mechs for every one 'Mech that Side B moves.

UNEQUAL NUMBER OF 'MECHS EXAMPLE TABLE

Move Number	'Mechs Left to Move		Moves	
	Side B	Side A	Side B	Side A
1	5	8	1	1
2	4	7	1	1
3	3	6	1	2
4	2	4	1	2
5	1	2	1	2

MOVEMENT MODE

The player moving a 'Mech must choose the movement mode the 'Mech will use this turn. All 'Mechs have at least three options (Standstill, Ground Move, or Sprinting), and some 'Mechs have a fourth option (Jumping).

Movement Tokens: After a 'Mech finishes its movement, place the appropriate token next to it to indicate it finished its Move.

MOVEMENT COST TABLE

Terrain Type	Movement Cost per Inch
Clear	1"
Rough/Rubble	+1"
Woods	+1"
Water	+1"
Building	+1–4"
Level Change (up or down) per 1" elevation	+2" (max 2" elevation per 2" moved)

STANDSTILL



A mobile 'Mech that chooses to move less than 1 inch in the current turn is at a standstill. A 'Mech that is standing still is easier to hit, but this also improves the 'Mech's ability to hit with its own attacks (see Attack Modifiers Table, p. 20).

GROUND MOVE



A 'Mech that moves at least 1 inch in the current turn, but does not use jumping movement, is using Ground Move. This is the default movement mode, so it does not affect the 'Mech's ability to hit with its own attacks.

SPRINTING



Any 'Mech may use Sprinting movement. To find its Sprint speed, multiply its current Ground Move by 1.5 and round up. (Sprinting may not be applied to a jumping Move.) Thus, a 'Mech with a current Move of 12" would have a Move of 18" when Sprinting (12" x 1.5 = 18"). The TMM of a Sprinting 'Mech is not changed.

A Sprinting 'Mech cannot attack or take any action other than movement. As such, it is is unable to fulfill any mission objectives that involve anything more than movement (scanning a building, picking up an object, etc.).

JUMPING



Any 'Mech with a "j" listed in its Move statistic is a 'Mech that possesses the ability to jump over intervening obstructions using jump jets. The distance such 'Mechs can jump is given as the Move value beside the "j". A jumping 'Mech ignores terrain costs for the purposes of movement. A jumping 'Mech may jump into water terrain, but not out of it.

Jumping movement always follows the shortest path possible; the player chooses an end point (up to the 'Mech's jumping Move allowance), and the 'Mech lands at that location, with any desired facing direction.

Jumping severely affects the 'Mech's ability to hit with its own attacks, but also makes it more difficult to be hit (see Attack Modifiers Table, p. 20).

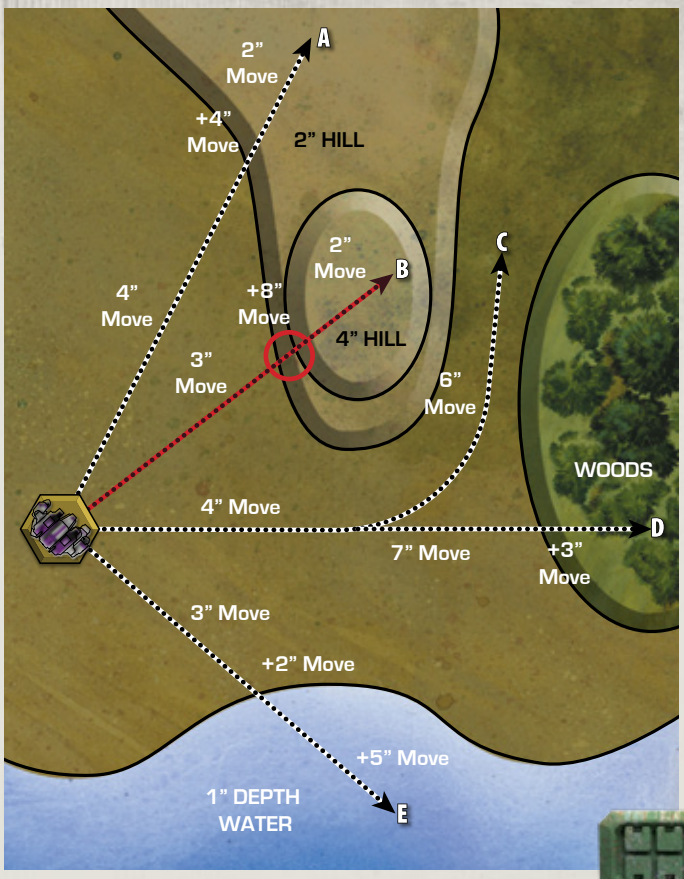
TERRAIN

As noted in Setup, in *Prepare to Play*, terrain may impede movement, costing an extra number of inches to enter or pass through. These extra costs are shown on the Movement Cost Table, at left. Note that multiple terrain conditions may combine for higher movement costs (such as when changing levels while moving through water).

Water: 'Mechs entering water must pay the combined cost of the movement, plus the extra movement costs for water terrain and any level change costs. As noted, water in *Alpha Strike* Quick-Start Rules is always a 1" depth.

Level Change: 'Mechs may climb onto and over terrain as steep as 2" high. Doing so costs an extra inch of movement per inch of level changed. (For an exception, see *Jumping*, at left). Level changes greater than these are considered prohibited terrain in *Alpha Strike*, too sheer for the 'Mech to traverse. If the 'Mech does not have enough Move allowance remaining to climb to the desired level of terrain, it must remain at the previous level, and cannot move any further.





• Movement Basics Diagram •

In the Movement Basics Diagram at left, the 'Mech has 10 inches of Movement. To move to Point A, it spends 4 inches of its available Move to get to the hill, 4 inches to move up the hill, and then 2 more inches to move across the hill. As it has run out of Move, the 'Mech stops there, and its controlling player can choose any facing for it to end with.

The 'Mech cannot move straight to Point B. The 4" level change is more than the 2" allowed for level changes per 1" traveled (much less not enough Move).

If the player wishes instead to avoid ending up on top of the hill, the 'Mech can move around the hill to reach Point C. In this case, it spends 4 inches to move below the hill, and its remaining 6 inches are spent moving up the gap between the hill and the woods.

The 'Mech can also move to Point D and end its movement in the Woods. For that, it spends 7 inches of Move to get to the edge of the woods. Because woods cost an extra 1 inch per inch traveled through such terrain, the 'Mech can only move 1.5 inches into the woods before running out of Move.

If the player would rather place their 'Mech in the water, they can move the 'Mech 3 inches to the water's edge, spend 2 inches of Move for the level change into the water and then spend 5 inches of Move to push through 2.5 inches of water terrain.



COMBAT PHASE

In the Combat Phase, each 'Mech may deliver one attack against another 'Mech, be it a weapon or physical attack.

To make an attack, the controlling player declares which 'Mech is attacking, what 'Mech it is attacking, the nature of the attack (weapon or physical), and—if applicable—how much of their 'Mech's Overheat Value the attack will use (see *Overheating*, p. 24). The player then resolves combat for that 'Mech, applies any damage to the target, and then moves on to another available 'Mech to repeat the process until all of their 'Mechs have made their attacks. If the player wishes a 'Mech not to make an attack, or if a 'Mech is unable to make an attack for any reason, the player may pass for that turn.

Once a player has resolved (or skipped) combat actions for all of their 'Mechs, the opposing player may then do so for all of their 'Mechs.

RESOLVING WEAPON ATTACKS

The sequence for resolving weapon attacks is as follows:

Step 1: Verify line of sight (LOS)
Step 2: Verify firing arc
Step 3: Determine range
Step 4: Making the attack
Step 5: Roll to hit
Step 6: Determine and apply damage
Step 7: Roll for critical hits (if applicable)

STEP 1: VERIFY LINE OF SIGHT

Line of sight (LOS) in *Alpha Strike* is determined by what a 'Mech can "see" from its vantage point on the table. 'Mechs can usually be sighted by simply going to the eye level of the attacking 'Mech and looking at the target miniature. If the target miniature can be seen, then the 'Mechs have LOS to one another. When this is not possible, players may determine line of sight by running a straight measuring tape or a taut string from miniature to miniature, or by using a laser pointer.

If less than one-third of a miniature is visible behind solid terrain (such as hills or buildings), then the line of sight is considered to be blocked.

Non-solid terrain—such as woods—does not automatically block LOS in the same fashion. In the case of such terrain, line of sight is only considered to be blocked when it passes through 6 inches or more of such intervening non-solid obstructions.

Woods that intervene, but do not block, LOS will impose an attack modifier (see the Attack Modifiers Table, p. 20).

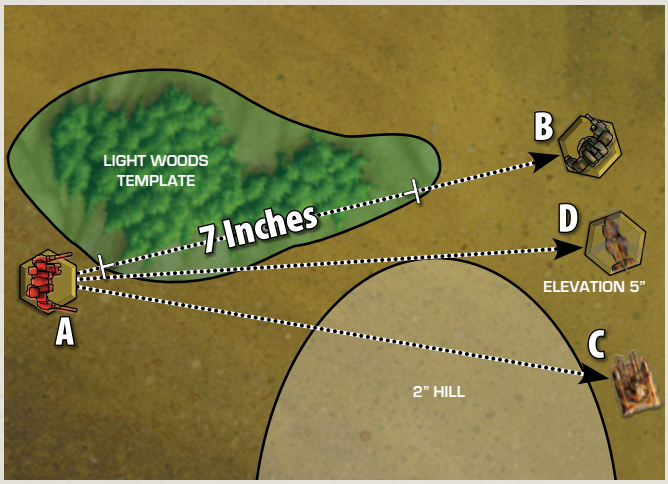
Adjacent Ground 'Mechs: 'Mechs in base-to-base contact always have line of sight to each other.

Intervening 'Mechs: Intervening 'Mechs are not treated as terrain, and thus have no effect on LOS or attacks.

Partial Cover: If more than one-third (but less than two-thirds) of a target is hidden behind blocking terrain, LOS is not considered blocked. Instead, the target is said to possess partial cover, and the attacker will apply an attack modifier as a result (see *Partial Cover Modifier*, p. 19).

Woods: 'Mechs do not receive partial cover from woods terrain.

Water: 'Mechs that are standing in Water terrain will receive partial cover benefits from the water. Because the water surrounds the 'Mech, this partial cover applies even if the attacker is standing at a higher level than the target and would ordinarily be able to see the target's legs.



• Line of Sight Diagram •

In the Line of Sight Diagram, above, BattleMech A wants to target BattleMech B. From the perspective of BattleMech A, the only thing the controlling player sees between the two units is a woods template. Using a measuring tape drawn between the two units to find how many inches of Woods terrain intervene, the player finds that he is trying to target a unit through 7 inches of intervening woods.

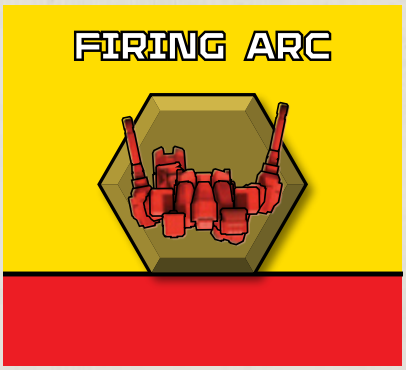
Because this is more than 6 inches, LOS between the two BattleMechs is actually blocked; BattleMech A therefore cannot attack BattleMech B.

The controlling player decides instead to target Ground Vehicle C. Unfortunately, when he leans down to the mini's level to check LOS, he finds that Vehicle C is actually hidden by the low ridge between them. This leaves only Vehicle D, a VTOL currently flying at a level of 5 inches above the table, as the only target that BattleMech A can see from its vantage point. BattleMech A's player notes that even this LOS passes over the woods terrain between them, and verifies with a straight-edge that the attack will pass through some wooded terrain.

STEP 2: VERIFY FIRING ARC

Every unit in *Alpha Strike* has a particular field of fire into which the unit may make attacks. These fields of fire, based on the unit's type and its facing, are known as firing arcs. A 'Mech's firing arc extend to the edge of the battlefield in the directions indicated by the Firing Arc Diagram, below.

If more than half of the target 'Mech's base lies outside the attacker's firing arc, then the attack cannot be made.



• Firing Arc Diagram •

S.A.T.O.R.

The attack process is not complicated—simply a matter of rolling 2D6 and trying to equal or exceed your modified Target Number.

After you understand the Target Number Modifiers section in this chapter, you'll find that "SATOR" is a helpful mnemonic that reminds you what needs to be taken into account:

- **S** Skill Rating of the attacker (the base Target Number for the attack). Then add:
- **A** Attacker Movement Modifer
- **T** Target Movement Modifier
- **O** Other Modifiers (typically terrain, partial cover, heat)
- **R** Range Modifiers

You start with your Skill Rating, then add all other applicable modifiers as indicated, and the result is your modified Target Number to roll against.

STEP 3: MAKING THE ATTACK

The base Target Number for all attacks is the 'Mech's Skill Rating. The modified Target Number equals the base Target Number plus all applicable modifiers for the attack's range bracket, the target's movement capability, terrain features, and other miscellaneous situations. The modifiers applicable to *Alpha Strike* are shown on the Attack Modifiers Table (see p. 20). Unless otherwise stated, all modifiers are cumulative, which means they are added to the 'Mech's base Target Number to find the final modified Target Number.

After you have your modified Target Number, roll 2D6 to see if the attack hits the target. If the result is equal to or greater than the modified Target Number, the attack hits.

If the modified Target Number is greater than 12, the attack automatically misses; rolling a 12 does not result in an automatic hit.

BASE TARGET NUMBER

SATOR

The base Target Number for an attack is equal to the attacker's Skill Rating.

TARGET NUMBER MODIFIERS

The base Target Number may be modified by several factors, as outlined below.

ATTACKER MOVEMENT MODIFIER

SATOR

A moving attacker's Target Number is modified by their own movement using the values in the Attack Modifiers Table (see p. 20).

The attacker's movement modifier is based on the movement mode it used in the turn.

Standstill and Immobile: Attacks made by a standstill or an immobile 'Mech (regardless of the attack type) receive a –1 Target Number modifier.

Jumping: Attacks made by a jumping 'Mech (regardless of the attack type) receive a +2 Target Number modifier.

TARGET MOVEMENT MODIFIER (TMM)

SATOR

A moving target is harder to hit, and so an attacker's Target Number is modified by its target movement modifier (see the Attack Modifiers Table, p. 20). The target movement modifier is listed on the unit card.

Ground Move: A 'Mech that moved 1 inch or more along the ground that turn, and did not jump, is using Ground Move. This is the default movement mode and uses the TMM as listed for the 'Mechs. (Sprinting uses the same TMM.)

Jumping: A 'Mech that jumps adds the additional +1 target movement modifier for jumping. Some 'Mechs have particularly strong (JMPS#) or weak (JMPW#) jump jets. Strong jump jets will add an additional target movement modifier, while weak jump jets will subtract from the target movement modifier when jumping.

In unusual circumstances, attacks can occur during the Movement Phase. If an attack against a jump-capable target is made before the target has moved this turn, assume the target used ground movement when resolving it (regardless of how the target moved the previous turn).

Immobile: An immobile 'Mech's TMM is always –4.



Standstill: A standstill 'Mech's TMM is always +0.

TERRAIN MODIFIERS

SATOR

Terrain can reduce the probability of a successful attack by forcing the attacker to account for intervening land features and partial cover.

Terrain is occupied if any part of the 'Mech's base is in contact with the terrain. Terrain is intervening if the line of sight passes through it before reaching the target (see *Verify Line of Sight*, p. 17).

Death From Above: This attack (see p. 22) ignores terrain modifiers.

Partial Cover: Attacks against a target in partial cover (see below) receive a +1 Target Number modifier.

Woods: Add a +1 modifier to an attack's Target Number if the line of sight has intervening wooded terrain more than 2" away from the attacker, or if the target occupies Woods terrain.

Water: 'Mechs that are standing in water terrain will receive partial cover benefits from the water (see *Partial Cover Modifier,* below).

PARTIAL COVER MODIFIER

SATOR

If more than one-third (but less than two-thirds) of a 'Mech target is hidden behind blocking terrain, the 'Mech is said to have partial cover. Attacks against a target with partial cover apply a +1 Target Number modifier.

Water: 'Mechs that are standing in depth 1" water terrain will receive partial cover benefits from the water.

Woods: This terrain does not provide partial cover.

HEAT MODIFIER

SATOR

The attacker's Target Number may suffer a modifier due to its heat build-up, as discussed in Engine Hit ('Mechs) and Overheating (see p. 23 and p. 24, respectively). The attacker applies a modifier to its Target Number equal to its current heat level.

DAMAGE MODIFIERS

SATOR

The attacker's Target Number may suffer additional modifiers for damage to its fire control as discussed in Fire Control Hit (see p. 23).

IMMOBILE TARGET MODIFIER

SATOR

Attacks against an immobile target apply a –4 Target Number modifier. The most common immobile targets are buildings, terrain, and shutdown 'Mechs. Do not apply this modifier unless a target is specifically stated to be immobile.

SPECIAL ABILITY MODIFIERS

SATOR

Some Special Abilities provide modifiers to attacks. If this is the case, it will be noted in that ability's description (see *Special Abilities*, p. 25). In addition, Special Pilot Abilities (SPAs), found on MechWarrior Cards (see p. 12), may also provide modifiers to attacks.

RANGE MODIFIER

SATOR

The farther away a target, the harder it is to hit. *Alpha Strike* uses fixed range brackets. To determine a 'Mech's range, hold the measuring tape or other measuring tool above both the attacker and the target, and measure the horizonal distance from the edge of the attacker's base to the edge of the target's base and compare this number to the *Alpha Strike* Range Table, at top right, to determine what range bracket the target lies in.

ALPHA STRIKE RANGE TABLE

Distance	Range	Modifier
Up to 6"	Short	+0
Over 6" and up to 24"	Medium	+2
Over 24" and up to 42"	Long	+4



ATTACK MODIFIERS TABLE (S.A.T.O.R.)

SKILL (S)	
Attacker	**Target Number**
Base Target Number	Skill Rating

ATTACKER MOVEMENT MODIFIERS (A)	
Attacker	**Modifier**
Jumping	+2
Standstill	–1
Ground Move	+0

TARGET MOVEMENT MODIFIERS (T)	
Target	**Modifier**
Ground Move/Sprinting	+TMM
Standstill	+0
Jumping	+TMM+1
JMPS#	+#
JMPW#	–#
Immobile	–4

OTHER MODIFIERS (O)	
Terrain	**Modifier**
Woods	+1
Partial Cover	+1
Attack	**Modifier**
Is from 'Mech with Fire Control Hit (per hit)	+2
Is from a 'Mech with Heat Level > 0	+Heat lvl[1]
Physical Attack Type	**Modifier**
Charge	+1
Death From Above (DFA)	+1
Stealth	**Modifier**
Has STL	S: +0 / M: +1 / L: +2

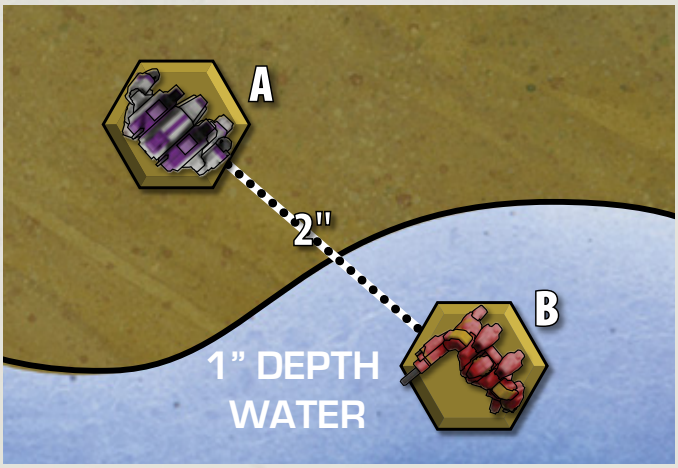
RANGE MODIFIERS (R)	
Attacker	**Target Number**
Short (Up to 6")	+0
Medium (>6" to 24")	+2
Long (>24" to 42")	+4

[1] Does not apply to physical attacks.

The range bracket a target is in determines the range modifier for an attack against that target. A short-range attack does not modify the attack's Target Number. A medium-range attack adds a +2 Target Number modifier, while a long-range attack adds a +4 modifier.

As noted, a 'Mech's successful attack will deliver a certain amount of damage to the target at each of the indicated ranges, but not all 'Mechs can deliver damage at every range bracket. If a 'Mech's damage value in a given range bracket is shown as a dash ("—") the 'Mech cannot make an effective weapon attack at that range. For the exception, see *Minimal Damage*, page 21.

Base-to-Base Contact: 'Mechs may not make weapon attacks against targets with which they are in base-to-base contact. Against such 'Mechs, the attacker may only deliver a physical attack (see *Physical Attacks*, p. 22).



• Attack Roll Diagram •

In the Attack Roll Diagram, above, Alice's ARC-5R Archer *stands at Point A and is attacking a PXH-3K* Phoenix Hawk *at Point B.*

***S (Skill):** Alice's 'Mech has a Skill rating of 3, establishing her base Target Number at 3.*

***A (Attacker):** Alice's 'Mech used Ground Move, for a +0 Target Number modifier. The modified Target Number is still at 3.*

***T (Target):** The target 'Mech has a listed TMM of +2, and it used a jumping move this turn. This adds the +2 TMM and +1 for jumping, and the modified Target Number is now 6.*

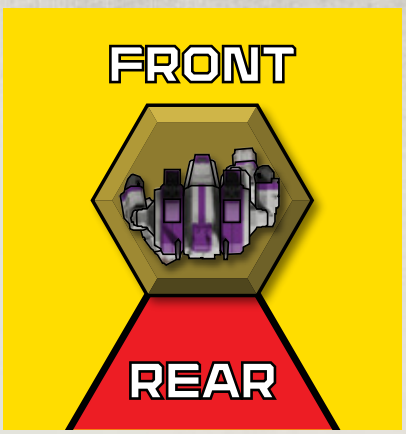
***O (Other):** The target* Phoenix Hawk *is in water which grants Partial Cover. This adds a +1 Target Number modifier, and the modified Target Number is now 7.*

***R (Range):** The* Phoenix Hawk *is 2 inches away, and thus at short range (no modifier). The final modified Target Number is 7.*

Alice will need to roll 7 or higher on 2D6 to successfully hit her target.

STEP 4: ROLL TO HIT

To execute an attack, the controlling player rolls 2D6 for each 'Mech and compares the total to the modified Target Number identified in the previous step. If the dice roll equals or exceeds the modified Target Number, that 'Mech's attack succeeds. Otherwise, the attack fails.



• Attack Direction Diagram •

STEP 5: DETERMINE AND APPLY DAMAGE

When an attack is successful, its damage is applied immediately, but damage effect will not take place until the End Phase. Before damage can be applied, the attack direction and amount of damage must be determined.

Attack Direction: When an attack hits a 'Mech, it must be determined whether or not it strikes the target's front or rear. To determine this, lay a straightedge from the center of the attacker's base to the center of the target's base. If the attack enters through the rear hex side of the target's base, the attack direction is to the target's rear. Otherwise, the damage applies to the front of the target. If the straightedge crosses at the intersection of two Front/Rear hex sides, the target chooses which side is hit by the attack.

Amount of Damage: The base amount of damage delivered by a successful weapon attack is equal to the attacking 'Mech's damage value (DV) at the appropriate range bracket. If the target is at short range, the base damage is that listed in the attacking 'Mech's S value. For a target at medium range, the M value is used. For a target at long range, the L damage value applies. Add 1 point of damage to any successful attack that strikes its target in the rear.

'Mechs that track heat may inflict additional damage on their targets at the expense of overheating. The decision to overheat for additional damage potential must be made when the attack is declared, but before it is resolved (see *Overheating*, p. 24).

Minimal Damage: Every time a 'Mech executes a successful attack at a range bracket with "0*" damage, its controlling player must make a 1D6 roll. If the result is 4 or higher, the attack delivers a single point of standard damage. Otherwise, the attack still hits, but delivers no damage. Successful minimal damage attacks that fail to deliver any actual damage may not resolve any Critical Hit checks.

Heat Special Ability: Some 'Mechs have a preponderance of heat-generating weapons. 'Mechs with this feature will reflect this in the 'Mech's stats via the Heat special ability (HT#/#/#). The Heat special ability will also include a numeric rating (for example, HT1/1/–), which will indicate the number of additional heat points that will be applied to a target in that range band (Short/Medium/Long) in the End Phase of the turn when the attack hits. (This heat applies in addition to the 'Mech's normal weapon attack damage, so a 'Mech that has a Short range damage value of 3 and has the HT1/–/– special will deliver 3 points of damage plus 1 point of heat at short range.)

OPTIONAL

MULTIPLE ATTACK ROLLS

Multiple Attack Rolls is an optional rule under which a 'Mech makes a separate attack roll for each point of damage, rather than a single attack roll for the 'Mech. Determine the amount of damage the attack can do, calculate the modified Target Number needed for the attack, and then roll a separate attack roll (2D6) for each point of damage. The number of successful attack rolls will then be the amount of damage applied to the target.

Despite rolling multiple attack rolls, the resulting damage remains a single attack and is applied to the target as a single attack. An attack only causes one critical hit when damaging structure, for example, not one critical hit per attack roll that damages structure. An anti-missile system reduces the total attack damage by 1 point (if applicable), not reducing each attack roll by 1.

Natural 12: The Natural 12 rule (see below) may only result in a maximum of one critical hit per target. Ignore any additional natural 12s from this 'Mech's attack rolls after the first 12.

Heat: If the 'Mech has the Heat (HT) special ability, the player may designate any one of the attack rolls per point of HT from the 'Mech as possessing the HT special ability. Each of the designated attacks will add one Heat to the target if successful, in addition to its damage. If the 'Mech has more HT than damage, roll a separate attack roll for each additional point of HT.

APPLYING DAMAGE

The following question-and-answer process covers the recording of damage from a successful attack.

Question 1: Was the attack roll a natural 12?

Yes: Roll once on the Determining Critical Hits Table on page 23. Proceed to Question 2.
No: Proceed to Question 2.

Question 2: Does the target 'Mech have armor (A) bubbles remaining on its unit card?

Yes: Check off one armor bubble for every point of damage delivered against the 'Mech, until all damage is applied or all armor is destroyed. Then proceed to Question 3.
No: Proceed to Question 3.

Question 3: Is there attack damage remaining?

Yes: Proceed to Question 4 to allocate remaining damage.
No: The attack is finished.

Question 4: Does the target 'Mech have structure (S) bubbles remaining?

Yes: Check off one structure bubble for every point of damage delivered, until all damage is applied or all structure is destroyed. Then proceed to Question 5.
No: Proceed to Question 5.

Question 5: Is there damage remaining?

Yes: The target 'Mech is destroyed.
No: Go to Question 6.

Question 6: Does the target 'Mech have structure bubbles remaining?

Yes: Roll once on the Determining Critical Hits Table (see *Step 6: Roll for Critical Hits*, p. 23). The attack is finished.
No: The target 'Mech is destroyed.

Matt's Nova *T begins the turn undamaged, and so it has 5 points of armor and 3 points of structure. This Combat Phase, the 'Mech is hit by weapon attacks from a WHM-8R* Warhammer *and a TR5* Wraith. *After checking the attack directions, Matt's opponents find all shots will strike his* Nova *on the front. The* Warhammer *is attacking from medium range and will thus deliver 4 points of damage. Matt marks off 4 armor bubbles, leaving 1 armor and 3 structure circles for his* Nova. *Because the damage has not marked off any structure bubbles, there is no Critical Hits roll.*

The Wraith, *also attacking from medium range, delivers 3 points of damage. Matt marks off the last bubble of armor on his* Nova *and 2 points of structure, leaving it with no armor bubbles and 1 bubble of structure.*

Matt informs his opponent that the attack has hit his structure. This means there is a chance for a Critical Hit. His opponent rolls 2D6, getting a 10 result, and consults the Determining Critical Hit Table. This means the Nova *has taken a Fire Control Hit. In future turns, the* Nova *will suffer an additional +2 Target Number modifier to its weapon attacks.*

PHYSICAL ATTACKS

Physical attacks follow a process similar to weapon attacks, however range is dealt with differently.

There are four types of physical attacks that 'Mechs may perform in *Alpha Strike*: Standard, Melee, and two forms of Special attacks. A 'Mech may only make one physical attack type per turn. 'Mechs cannot make a physical attack in the same turn they have made a weapon attack. The base Target Number for all physical attacks is the 'Mech's Skill rating. This Target Number is modified based on the physical attack type chosen, the target's movement capability, terrain features, and other miscellaneous situations. The modifiers applicable to physical attacks are shown on the Attack Modifiers Table (see p. 20).

STANDARD PHYSICAL ATTACKS

Standard physical attacks consist of punches and kicks where the 'Mech uses its limbs to inflict damage on a target. Standard physical attacks can only occur when the attacker is within 1 inch of its target, and the target is within the attacking 'Mech's firing arc (see *Verify Firing Arcs*, p. 18).

Damage Value: Standard physical attack damage is equal to the 'Mech's Size value.

MELEE PHYSICAL ATTACKS

Only 'Mechs with the Melee (MEL) special ability may make Melee physical attacks. The 'Mech uses a weapon instead of its normal physical attack. 'Mechs that have a Melee special ability may not choose to make a Standard physical attack instead.

Melee physical attacks can only occur when the attacking 'Mech is within 2 inches of its target and the target 'Mech is also within the attacking 'Mech's firing arc (see *Verify Firing Arcs*, p. 18). If a 'Mech is at a different level than the attacker, the difference in level is added to the distance. Thus, a 'Mech on a hill at the edge of a 2" range of Melee and 1" above the attacker could not be attacked by a Melee physical attack.

Damage Value: Melee physical attack damage is equal to the 'Mech's Size value plus 1.

SPECIAL PHYSICAL ATTACKS

Charge and Death from Above (DFA) attacks are more aggressive and risky physical attacks. Only one of these special physical attacks may be attempted per target, per turn—once a 'Mech has been targeted for a Special physical attack, it cannot be the target of any further Special physical attacks.

Charges and Death From Above attacks are declared in the Movement Phase. They can only be declared if the attacking 'Mech can move far enough to end its movement in base-to-base contact with its target, and only against targets that have already completed their movement. (In addition, a Death from Above attack may only be attempted by 'Mechs that have sufficient jumping Move to reach the target.) Once declared, they cannot be aborted or changed by the attacker.

CHARGE ATTACKS

In a Charge attack, the attacking 'Mech uses a Ground Move to ram into its target, using its mass and speed to deliver damage. A successful Charge will thus damage both the attacker and the target. The charging 'Mech's damage is equal to its Size plus half its Target Movement Modifier (rounded down). Thus, a Size 3 'Mech with TMM +3 would deal 4 damage with a successful charge.

Damage to Attacker: If the Charge attack is successful, the attacking 'Mech also suffers half its Target Movement Modifier (rounded down) in damage, plus 1 point of damage if its target is Size 3 or higher. This does not count as an attack by the target.

DEATH FROM ABOVE ATTACK

In order to execute a Death from Above (DFA) attack, the attacking 'Mech must have jumping movement. On a successful DFA attack, the attacking 'Mech delivers damage to its target equal to its Charge damage +1 (see *Charge Attacks*, above). A successful DFA attack will give the attacker one roll to deliver a critical hit, even if the target's armor is not destroyed (see *Roll for Critical Hits*, p. 23).

Damage to Attacker: If the DFA attack succeeds, the attacking 'Mech also suffers damage equal to its own Size. This damage does not count as an attack from the target. If the DFA fails, the attacking 'Mech suffers damage equal to 1 plus its own Size value.

STEP 6: ROLL FOR CRITICAL HITS

Any time a hit damages structure, critical damage may occur that further weakens or impairs the target 'Mech. To determine whether a 'Mech suffers a critical hit—and the nature of such damage—the attacker rolls 2D6 and consults the Determining Critical Hits Table, at bottom right. Critical Hits must be clearly marked on the 'Mech's card. The effects of all critical hits are permanent.

If the given critical hit effect does not apply to the 'Mech in question (for example, a weapon hit on a 'Mech that has already had all of its damage values reduced to zero), apply 1 additional point of damage to the 'Mech instead, but do not roll for additional critical hits as a result of this extra damage.



CRITICAL HIT EFFECTS

The following describes the effects of each critical hit type described in the Determining Critical Hits Table, below.

Ammo Hit: Unless the 'Mech has the CASE, CASEII, or ENE special abilities, the 'Mech is destroyed. If the 'Mech has CASE, it suffers 1 additional point of damage (roll again on the Determining Critical Hits Table if this damages structure). If the 'Mech has the CASEII or ENE special abilities, apply no additional damage and treat the result as No Critical Hit.

Engine Hit: The 'Mech's power system has been damaged. The 'Mech generates 1 heat point when it fires its weapons, without delivering any extra damage from overheating. (The 'Mech can still use overheating to add damage, but this heat adds to the 1 point generated by the engine hit.) The 'Mech gains heat from this critical hit in the first End Phase following the Engine Hit if it fired its weapons in the Combat Phase of that turn. A second Engine Hit critical destroys the 'Mech.

Fire Control Hit: Damage has rendered the 'Mech's weapons less accurate. Each Fire Control Hit adds a cumulative attack modifier of +2 for all subsequent weapon attacks by the damaged 'Mech. (This modifier does not apply to physical attacks.)

MP Hit: Something related to the 'Mech's ability to move has been damaged. The affected 'Mech halves its Move and TMM, rounding down. Each MP Hit reduces the MV by a minimum of 2" and TMM by 1, until a minimum MV and TMM of 0. If the affected unit has the JMPS special ability, reduce JMPS# by 1, to a minimum JMPS0. If a 'Mech is reduced to a Move of 0 inches (or less) in this fashion, the 'Mech is immobile (place that token next to it).

No Critical Hit: The hit causes no critical effect.

'Mech Destroyed: The 'Mech has suffered fatal damage. (Remove the 'Mech from the game at the end of this turn.)

Weapon Hit: Some of the 'Mech's weapons have been destroyed. All damage values are reduced by 1 (to a minimum of 0). Weapon Hits do not affect a 'Mech's physical attack values.

DETERMINING CRITICAL HITS TABLE

2D6 Roll	Effect
2	Ammo Hit
3	Engine Hit
4	Fire Control Hit
5	No Critical Hit
6	Weapon Hit
7	MP Hit
8	Weapon Hit
9	No Critical Hit
10	Fire Control Hit
11	Engine Hit
12	'Mech Destroyed

HEAT

On a unit card, the boxed numbers and the letter "S," to the right of the Overheat Value (OV), represent the 'Mech's heat scale. When a 'Mech overheats, the amount by which it overheats is added to the 'Mech's heat level, which is then marked on the heat scale, and applies the following effects in the next turn:

- A 'Mech's current heat level will be added to its weapon attack Target Numbers.
- Twice its current heat level (in inches) will be subtracted from the 'Mech's Move rating.
- Subtract 1 from the 'Mech's target movement modifier (TMM) at Heat Level 2 or higher.
- Move and TMM are not affected by the heat scale when using Jumping movement.

Remember that heat levels do not actually change until the End Phase of the turn in which the 'Mech overheated. Thus, modifiers caused by overheating do not impact the attack that causes the overheating to begin with; they will instead affect the 'Mech during its next turn.

Heat (HT#/#/#) Special Ability: The Heat special ability (see p. 25) reflects 'Mechs that are capable of raising a target 'Mech's heat via outside heat sources (such as flamer weapons). In a single turn, no 'Mech may receive more than 2 points of heat from attacks made using this special ability. If a 'Mech capable of building heat has already generated 2 points of heat during the turn from HT#/#/# attacks, the 'Mech does not receive any additional heat effects; instead, the extra heat points from these attacks are simply lost.

End Phase Heat Application: Any source that applies heat during the End Phase does so before Cooling Down occurs (at right).

SHUTDOWN

The maximum heat level of 4 appears on the heat scale as an S, which represents automatic shutdown. A 'Mech reaching this level on the heat scale shuts down, and cannot expend Move or execute any attacks in the following turn. If the 'Mech contains any special electronics (such as AMS), that equipment will also stop working while the 'Mech is shutdown.

While shutdown, a 'Mech is rendered immobile. As such, it has a target movement modifier of –4. (Place an Immobile token next to it.)

OVERHEATING

Many 'Mechs have an Overheat Value (OV) other than zero shown on the unit card. This number reflects the fact that these 'Mechs have more weapons than they can safely fire. A warrior piloting such a 'Mech can push it beyond its safety limits to inflict extra damage. However, as noted, the heat build-up caused by such action will slow the 'Mech down and cause its targeting systems to behave erratically until the 'Mech has a chance to cool off.

USING OVERHEAT VALUE

An attacking player must announce their use of Overheat Value—and how many points of OV they wish to use—before resolving the Attack Roll. A 'Mech with OV can apply anywhere from a minimum of 1 OV points to a maximum equal to the 'Mech's OV rating. If the attack succeeds, it deals extra damage at the Short or Medium range brackets equal to the OV points used when the attack was announced.

For each point of Overheat Value a 'Mech uses in this fashion, one point of Heat is added to the 'Mech's Heat Scale in the End Phase.

Special Ability Damage: Special abilities that deliver damage (or heat) effects (such as HT, IF, and REAR) may not be augmented by overheating.

Physical Attacks: Physical attacks cannot be augmented by overheating.

Overheat Long (OVL) Special Ability: If a 'Mech has the OVL special ability (see p. 25), its use of Overheat will also increase its damage value in the Long range bracket in the same manner as it will for Short and Medium range.

COOLING DOWN (END PHASE)

During Cooldown, the 'Mech begins the End Phase with the Heat level it had at the end of the previous turn's End Phase.

Apply Heat to the 'Mech for this End Phase in the following order:

Step 1: Add any Overheat used by the 'Mech this turn.

Step 2: Subtract 1 heat level if the 'Mech is in water.

Step 3: Remove all heat levels if the 'Mech did not make a weapon attack this turn.

Step 4: Remove all heat levels and restart the 'Mech if the 'Mech began this End Phase shutdown.

Step 5: Add any external sources of Heat.

Overheating: Any 'Mech that used Overheating in the current turn will increase its Heat level as mentioned above, and thus will not cool down at all in the End Phase.

The Timber Wolf Prime *(*Mad Cat*) has the following stats on its unit card: Damage (S/M/L) 5/5/4, OV 1, and has the LRM 1/1/2 and IF2 special abilities, but not the OVL special ability. With the OV of 1, it can overheat by 1 point in a turn. This means it can inflict up to 6 points of damage at Short and Medium range (5 + 1 = 6), but still delivers only 4 points of damage at Long range due to the lack of the OVL special ability. (Its IF and LRM special abilities, however, cannot be improved by using OV points.)*

In the next turn, the Timber Wolf *can overheat by 1 additional level to maintain its augmented damage, raising its heat scale to 2 points. If the* Timber Wolf *does this again for two more consecutive turns, its heat scale will continue to rise until hitting its maximum level (shutdown).*

SPECIAL ABILITIES

Special abilities reflect extra features of a 'Mech's performance created by its equipment or unit type. While most of these provide 'Mechs with additional benefits, some special abilities may also reflect handicaps or restrictions. If a special ability contradicts the basic gameplay rules, the ability takes precedence.

'Mechs may have multiple special abilities. The special ability descriptions below describe only the abilities usable in *Alpha Strike* Quick-Start Rules. Any special abilities not found in the list below have no effect in the Quick-Start level of play (for the specific cards in this box, they are AC2/2/–, ECM, Omni, LRM1/1/1, and LRM1/1/2), but may be used under the *Alpha Strike: Commander's Edition* rules.

SPECIAL ABILITY DESCRIPTIONS

These abilities are listed by name, with their abbreviation given in parentheses. Special abilities followed by a numeric designator (#) indicates they may have variable effect based on the number used. For example, a 'Mech with HT1/–/– indicates a 'Mech that can deliver 1 heat point in a successful attack against a targeted 'Mech at short range, while a 'Mech with HT2/–/– can deliver 2 heat points.

ANTI-MISSILE SYSTEM (AMS)

A 'Mech with an AMS reduces the damage by 1 point (to a minimum of 1) from a 'Mech with the IF or LRM special abilities. AMS only works on attacks coming in the front arc; it also works even if those abilities apply no effect (such as in these QSR).

CASE (CASE)

'Mechs with this ability can minimize the catastrophic effects of an ammunition explosion and thus can survive Ammo Hit critical hits (see *Ammo Hit*, p. 23), but will suffer additional damage.

CASE II (CASEII)

'Mechs with this ability have superior protection against ammunition explosions and can ignore Ammo Hit critical hits (see *Ammo Hit*, p. 23).

ENERGY (ENE)

A 'Mech with this ability has little to no ammo to explode, and ignores Ammo Hit critical hits (see *Ammo Hit*, p. 23).

HEAT (HT#/#/#)

'Mechs with this ability apply heat to the target's Heat scale during the End Phase of the turn in which they deliver a successful weapon attack at the range indicated.

MELEE (MEL)

This special ability indicates that the 'Mech is equipped with a physical attack weapon, and adds 1 additional point of physical attack damage on a successful Melee physical attack (see *Physical Attacks*, p. 22).



OVERHEAT LONG (OVL)

A 'Mech with this special ability may overheat up to its OV value and apply that value to its Long range damage value as well as the 'Mech's Short and Medium range damage values. (A 'Mech without this special ability may only apply the damage benefits of its Overheat capabilities to damage delivered in the Short and Medium range brackets.)

REAR-FIRING WEAPONS (REAR#/#/#)

This 'Mech may attack 'Mechs that are not in its firing arc, using the damage values of the Rear special ability but with an additional +1 Target Number modifier.

A 'Mech attempting a REAR attack may still deliver normal forward firing attacks in the same turn, but its ability to do so is reduced. To reflect this, if a 'Mech makes an attack using the REAR special ability, for every point of REAR damage it can inflict, its forward-arc damage for that turn must be reduced by the same amount. This damage reduction is applied before the use of any additional damage made possible by overheating.

STEALTH (STL)

For attacks made against targets with the STL special, apply an additional +1 Target Number modifier to attacks at Medium range, and an additional +2 modifier at Long range.

PLAY THIS SCENARIO FIRST!

MEET AND GREET

Abbie Davidson stopped her 'Mech atop the ridge line. The vantage point gave a good overlook on the enemy 'Mechs on the plains below. Choosing one and increasing magnification, she saw the Clan Jade Falcon emblem brazenly displayed on its shoulder.

"Lainey, you're the fastest," she said over her lance channel. "Get back to base camp and confirm we've got Jade Falcons on the ground here. Everyone else, let's see if we can get some answers up front."

Abbie kept her focus on the Falcons as the 'Mech darted off behind her. Slowly counting down, she finally flipped on an open channel. "Jade Falcons. I am Lieutenant Abigail Davidson of Northwind. I claim this ridge, and the plain before us."

Kenneth's voice piped up on her comms. "Ma'am, there's a lot of them out there…"

She flipped off her open comms. "I'm counting on that. There's no honor in defeating an enemy five to one. I'm offering them the opportunity of earning some. And here they come now."

A pair of Falcon 'Mechs broke ranks and advanced on the ridge. They stopped a few hundred meters from the Highlanders before responding. "I am Star Commander Mai of Clan Jade Falcon. I accept your challenge."

SITUATION

Though the field of battle and the stakes of victory are of doubtful importance, both sides seek to prove themselves. The winner will secure bragging rights, while the loser will look for an opportunity to even the score.

GAME SETUP

The Attacker are advance elements of Clan Jade Falcon, while the Defender are a lance of the Northwind Highlanders.

Each player selects four singular trees as their terrain choices. The attacker places terrain first. The players alternate placing each terrain piece on the battlefield, within 24" of the center of the battlefield. Each player must place three of their trees within 4" of each other to form a triangle-shaped woods template between them. Other than these woods, no piece of terrain may be placed within 4" of another piece of terrain.



DEFENDER

The Defender consists of one lance of the Northwind Highlanders:

Lieutenant Abigail Davidson (Skill 3), BJ-5 *Blackjack*
Sergeant Marcus Abercrombie (Skill 3), PXH-4M *Phoenix Hawk*
MechWarrior Kenneth McLeod (Skill 4), WSP-5A *Wasp*
MechWarrior Arthur Bran (Skill 4), LCT-7V *Locust*

ATTACKER

The Attacker are a pair of scouts from Clan Jade Falcon:

Star Commander Mai (Skill 2), *Nova* T
MechWarrior Ellis (Skill 3), *Pouncer* T

DEPLOYMENT

The Defender chooses two of their BattleMechs and places them at least 20" from the center of the battlefield, toward their home edge. The Attacker then chooses one of their BattleMechs and places it at least 20" from the center of the battlefield toward their home edge. The players alternate placing their 'Mechs in this way, the Highlanders player placing two 'Mechs for each one Jade Falcon 'Mech placed, until all six 'Mechs are on the battlefield.

VICTORY CONDITIONS

The winner is the Force which cripples or destroys all opposing 'Mechs first.

SPECIAL RULES

FORCED WITHDRAWAL

Forced Withdrawal is in effect for in this scenario (see *Forced Withdrawal*, p. 12).



BUILDINGS

In *Alpha Strike*, any buildings present on the battlefield can serve as cover or impede movement, or become objectives to capture or destroy. This box includes fifteen fold-up buildings.

BUILDING TYPES

Buildings are divided into four broad categories that define both their structural strength and overall size in *Alpha Strike*: Light, Medium, Heavy, and Hardened. Each of these building types is further described by its construction factor (CF)—a value that approximates how much damage the building can sustain before it is reduced to rubble. While there are default values below, players are free to assign whatever values work for their scenarios, within the indicated CF Range.

Light Buildings: Light buildings in *Alpha Strike* run the gamut from small tents, huts, and sheet metal hangars to small family homes, convenience stores, and shops. The maximum CF for a Light building in *Alpha Strike* is 5, and they have a default CF of 3.

Medium Buildings: Medium buildings are sturdier, moderate-sized structures, such as warehouses, office buildings, apartment complexes and the like. These buildings comprise the bulk of most residential settlements and commercial complexes in the *BattleTech* setting. Medium buildings have a maximum CF of 8, and a default CF of 4. The nine smaller buildings from this box are Medium.

Heavy Buildings: Heavy buildings are large, reinforced structures, including factories, hospitals, government buildings, and permanent command centers. Heavy buildings can have a CF as high as 18 in *Alpha Strike*, with a default CF of 12. The six larger buildings from this box are Heavy.

Hardened Buildings: Hardened buildings are armored or otherwise battle-reinforced fortifications, built specifically to withstand siege warfare and perhaps any explosives shy of a nuclear blast. Hardened buildings in *Alpha Strike* can have a maximum CF of 40, with a default of 20.

MOVEMENT EFFECTS

The Move Cost per Inch column on the *Alpha Strike* Buildings Table (see at right) defines the additional Move cost for 'Mechs to maneuver through buildings. 'Mechs may not end their movement in buildings. In addition, unless noted otherwise below, any 'Mech that moves through a building will deliver 1 point of damage to that building for every inch of travel within the structure.

CLIMBING AND STANDING ON BUILDINGS

A 'Mech can move to the roof of a building to gain a better vantage point over the battlefield. Along the outside of buildings, 'Mechs can climb up and down the structures' face in the same manner as they can ascend or descend the changes in ground levels, with a maximum level change of 2 inches. Jump-capable 'Mechs may alternatively jump onto a building's rooftop, as long as they have sufficient jumping Move to reach that level.

Building Weight Capacity: Each building has a weight capacity limit listed on the *Alpha Strike* Buildings Table. This value is an abstraction of the tonnage limits for buildings in that class and is the maximum total of the Size classes of all 'Mechs attempting to stand on the building. If the total number of all Size values for all 'Mechs present on a building exceeds this capacity, the entire structure will collapse (see *Building Collapse*, below). If this happens during movement, the movement of the last 'Mech to attempt to stand on the building ends as soon as it exits the building and the collapse is then resolved.

For example, a Medium building—weight capacity 2—can support up to two Size 1 'Mechs because the combined Size classes for the two 'Mechs would be 1 + 1 = 2.

ATTACKING BUILDINGS

Under these rules, buildings may be attacked in the same manner as any other unit type. Attacks against buildings are resolved as against an immobile target. Damage to a building is applied to the building's CF. A building's type will remain unchanged, regardless of its current CF. Thus, a Heavy building reduced to only 3 points of CF will still be treated as a Heavy building for movement, weight capacity, and damage absorption purposes.

BUILDING COLLAPSE

All damage delivered to a building is applied to the building's construction factor, reducing its integrity. If the building's CF is reduced to 0, it will collapse. Likewise, if a building's weight capacity is exceeded at any level, it will collapse.

Any 'Mechs moving through or on top of a collapsing building will suffer damage based on the height of the building and the building's type. The collapse damage value is multiplied by every 4 full inches of building height (round down, to a minimum of 1). Add 1 more point of damage to any 'Mechs that are standing on the building's rooftop when it collapses.

When a building collapses, remove it immediately. The space it previously occupied is now filled with rubble. You can either remember that, or place in a template you've made.

ALPHA STRIKE BUILDINGS TABLE

Building Type	Move Cost per Inch	CF Range (Default)	Weight Capacity	Collapse Damage
Light	+1"	1–5 (3)	2	0*
Medium	+2"	2–8 (4)	4	1
Heavy	+3"	6–18 (12)	6	2
Hardened	+4"	10–40 (20)	8	4

BATTLEFIELD SUPPORT

Battlefield Support rules bring artillery and aerospace support to the *Alpha Strike* game without requiring miniatures of those units or their expanded rules. The following light rules bring these types of support elements into any game.

BEFORE PLAY BEGINS

Players pay for Battlefield Support using Battlefield Support Points. If a scenario does not provide details for Battlefield Support, then the players must determine the amount of Battlefield Support Points (BSPs) they will have available before the game begins:

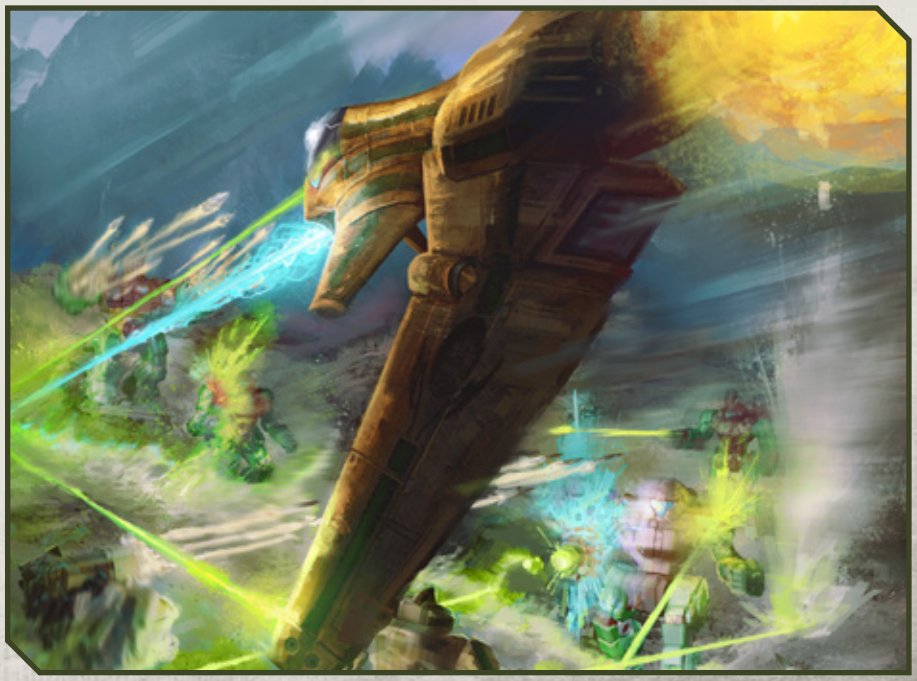
- Extraction Raid Support: 5 BSPs
- Objective Raid Support: 12 BSPs

Once the players have determined the amount of Battlefield Support Points they will have to spend, they should secretly select and write down the specific Battlefield Support Types they will have available in their scenario, as noted on the *Alpha Strike* Battlefield Support Table (see p. 30).

For example, if two players decide to use Objective Raid Support (12 BSPs), Player A may simply want three Aerospace Heavy Bombing (4 BSPs each), while Player B opts for two Aerospace Light Strikes (2 BSPs each), an Aerospace Heavy Strike (3 BSPs), one Thumper Artillery (3 BSPs) and one Sniper Artillery (2 BSPs).

The BSP cards in this box make selecting and using Battlefield Support easier during a scenario.

One-Time Use: Each selection of a Battlefield Support Type is usable once only, whether it inflicts damage or not. Use of the same Battlefield Support Type requires the purchase of multiple instances of that type before play begins.



DURING GAME PLAY

Use the following rules for each Battlefield Support Type:

Attack Declaration: Use the following rules when declaring an attack:

- If a Support Type is to be used, it must be declared during the Combat Phase of the turn it will be used. The player reveals their selection of that Support Type, but does not need to reveal all choices of that Support Type.
- The controlling player declares the target 'Mech or Point of Impact (POI) on the battlefield for the attack.

Target Numbers: No modifiers are applied to the Target Numbers shown on the Battlefield Support Table. Players simply roll 2D6, comparing the result against the Target Number for that Support Type, to determine whether the attack is successful.

Terrain and Levels (Hills): For these QSR, neither terrain, levels (hills), nor buildings affect Battlefield Support damage in any way.

OFFENSIVE AEROSPACE SUPPORT (STRIKES)

Light Strike Target Number: 5

Heavy Strike Target Number: 6

Successful Attack: If the attack is successful, apply the damage value to the target 'Mech.

Unsuccessful Attack: If the attack fails, nothing occurs.

OFFENSIVE AEROSPACE SUPPORT (BOMBING)

Light Bombing Target Number: 5

Heavy Bombing Target Number: 7

Successful Attack: If the attack is successful, place the Area of Effect Template on the target or POI; all 'Mech bases touched by the template take damage equal to the damage value for the type of attack, as indicated on the Alpha Strike Battlefield Support Table.

Unsuccessful Attack: If the attack fails, it will scatter. Using the Area of Effect Template, with the "1" location indicating the map's "northern" direction, the attacker rolls 1D6 and uses the numbers around the template to find which of the 6 possible directions the missed bombing attack will scatter. Once direction is determined, a second 1D6 roll result—multiplied by 2—then determines how many inches from the original target or POI the missed shot will actually land. The new location becomes the center of the actual impact, and damages targets within the Area of Effect.

ARTILLERY SUPPORT

Thumper Target Number: 7

Sniper Target Number: 8

Targeting: Artillery targets a Point of Impact (POI), rather than a 'Mech.

Successful Attack: If the attack is successful, place the Area of Effect Template on the POI; all 'Mech bases touched by the template take damage equal to the damage value for the type of attack, as indicated on the Alpha Strike Battlefield Support Table.

Unsuccessful Attack: If the attack fails, it will scatter. Using the Area of Effect Template, with the "1" location indicating the map's "northern" direction, the attacker rolls 1D6 and uses the numbers around the template to find which of the 6 possible directions the missed artillery attack will scatter. Once direction is determined, a second 1D6 roll result—multiplied by 2—then determines how many inches from the original target or POI the missed shot will actually land. The new location becomes the center of the actual impact, and damages targets within the Area of Effect.



ALPHA STRIKE BATTLEFIELD SUPPORT TABLE

Support Type	Target Number*	Damage Value	BSP Cost
Offensive Aerospace Support			
Light Strike	5	1	2
Light Bombing[1]	5	1	3
Heavy Strike	6	2	3
Heavy Bombing[1]	7	2	4
Artillery Support[1]			
Thumper	7	1[2]	2
Sniper	8	2[2]	3

* No modifiers are applied to this Target Number.

[1] Scatters if it misses.

[2] Area of Effect.



• AREA EFFECT TEMPLATE •

PLAY THIS SCENARIO SECOND!

CLASH OF STEEL

"We are a go."

The moment his commline squawked, MechWarrior Demetrius kicked his 'Mech into a run. Each step pounded into the pavement, and he leaned his 'Mech into a turn at the intersection as the sounds of artillery blasts rocked the streets.

"Star Captain, the target is well-defended. The surats *must be up to something important."*

"Aff, MechWarrior. Fulfill the needs of the Clan and teach them the futility of their resistance."

Demetrius smiled. After a day of hunting, the Talons were ready to go for the kill. It was almost enough to make him scream out his eagerness. Almost.

Racing around another corner, the first Highlander 'Mech appeared in his sights. As his lasers lanced out at the target, Demetrius gave in to the impulse and put voice to a year of impatience. An echo filtered through his comms as his Star repeated the cry.

"ilKhan!"

SITUATION

Neither side is looking for a big, conclusive battle. The Jade Falcons do not have the numbers, and the Highlanders don't want to die for a simple recon contract. But neither wants to withdraw in the face of their enemy. Looking to split the Falcons in order to force smaller engagements, the Highlanders advance into the ruined city of Aswan to play a game of cat and mouse.

GAME SET-UP

The Attacker is a Star of Clan Jade Falcon, while the Defender is two lances from the Northwind Highlanders.

Each player selects three trees, three smaller buildings and three larger buildings as their terrain choices. The attacker places terrain first. The players alternate placing two terrain pieces at a time on the battlefield, within 24" of the center of the battlefield. Any trees within 4" of another tree (no matter which player placed the trees) will form a template of woods.

DEFENDER

The defender consists of two lances of Northwind Highlanders:

Command Lance
- Captain Crow Hughes (Skill 3), AS7-S4 *Atlas*
- Sergeant Oswald Alexander (Skill 3), ARC-7C *Archer*
- MechWarrior Brian Harris (Skill 3), WHM-8R *Warhammer*
- MechWarrior Bonnie Rona (Skill 3), BJ-5 *Blackjack*

Recon Lance
- Lieutenant Kenna Keir (Skill 3), TR5 *Wraith*
- Sergeant Michael Mackenzie (Skill 3), WSP-5A *Wasp*
- MechWarrior Sean Harris (Skill 3), PXH-4M *Phoenix Hawk*
- MechWarrior Aminatta Sunderland (Skill 3), LCT-7V *Locust*

ATTACKER

The Attacker is a Clan Jade Falcon Battle Star:

- Star Commander Nur Icaza (Skill 1), *Warhawk* T
- MechWarrior Enoli Clees (Skill 2), *Timber Wolf* T
- MechWarrior Mark (Skill 2), *Nova* T
- MechWarrior Elena (Skill 2), *Pouncer* T
- MechWarrior Demetrius (Skill 2), *Fire Moth* G

DEPLOYMENT

The Attacker chooses one of their BattleMechs and places it at least 24" from the center of the battlefield toward their home edge. The Defender then chooses two of their BattleMechs and places them at least 24" from the center of the battlefield toward their home edge. The players alternate placing their 'Mechs in this way until all 'Mechs are on the battlefield.

VICTORY CONDITIONS

The winner is the Force which cripples or destroys all opposing 'Mechs first.

SPECIAL RULES

BATTLEFIELD SUPPORT

Both sides secretly choose 5 points worth of Battlefield Support.

FORCED WITHDRAWAL

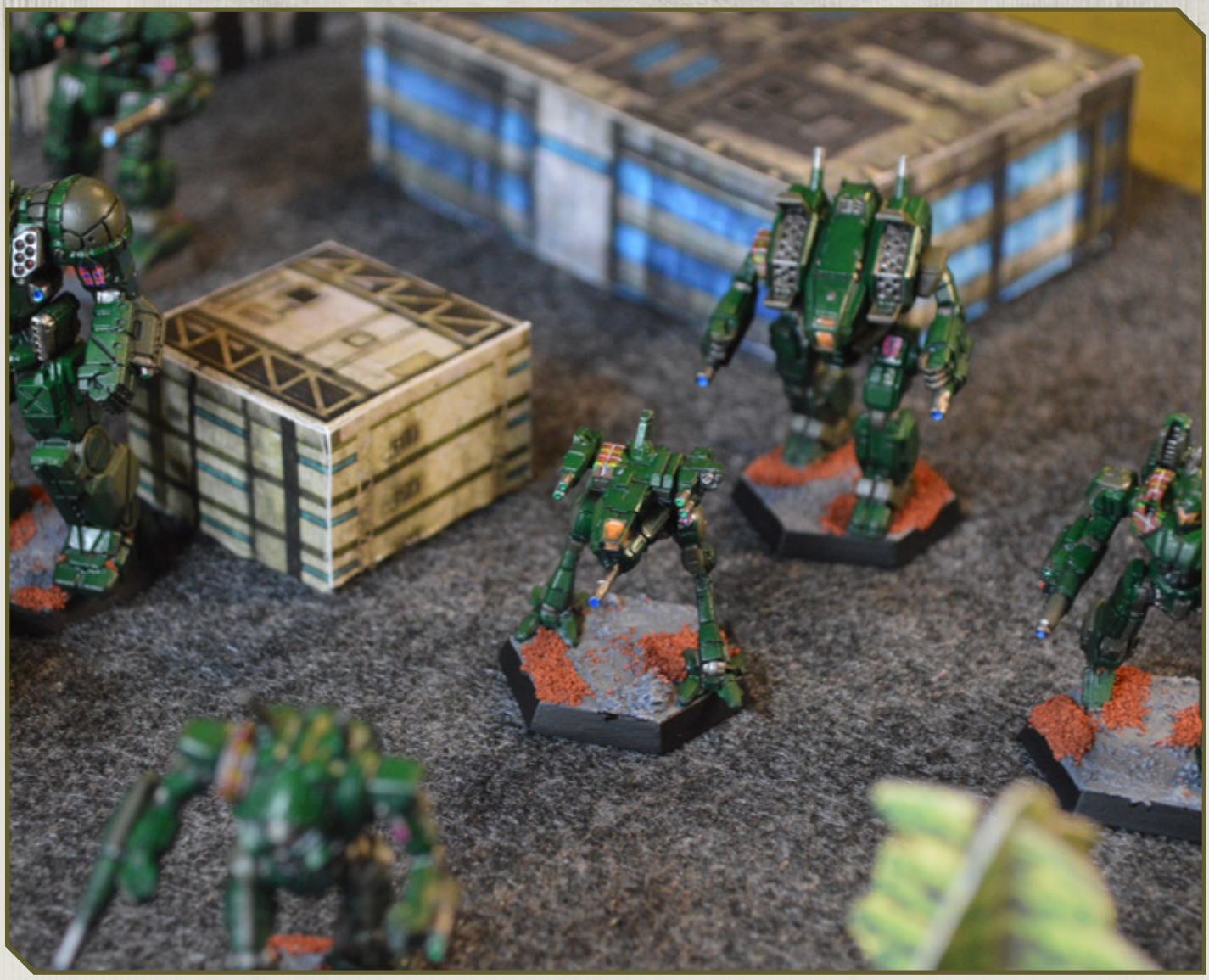
Forced Withdrawal is in effect for this scenario (see *Forced Withdrawal*, p. 12).

FORMATIONS

Formation rules are in effect and the pertinent rules are summarized below. Formation rules add flavor to the game by enhancing the effectiveness of Formations—that is, 'Mechs grouped together for specific tasks within your Force. Rules for Force Building and Formations immediately follow this scenario.

The Defender uses the Command and Recon Lance Formations and the Attacker uses the Battle Star Formation.

PLAY THIS SCENARIO SECOND!



COMMAND LANCE

At the start of the scenario, the player designates two 'Mechs (which cannot include the *Atlas*) in the Command Lance as having **Combat Intuition**.

A Command Lance provides the following two abilities:

- As long as the *Atlas* is not destroyed, its controlling player may reroll Initiative Rolls once per turn. However, this second roll stands, even if it fails or is worse than the first.
- **Combat Intuition:** If the controlling player wins Initiative, the 'Mechs with **Combat Intuition** can move and resolve all of its attacks during the Movement Phase, applying all damage effects immediately—before any target 'Mechs can act. This ability can only be used once by each 'Mech every 3 turns.

RECON LANCE

All members of the Recon Star receive the **Maneuvering Ace** ability:

- **Maneuvering Ace:** Each 'Mech reduces the cost for moving through all woods terrain types by 1 inch per inch of movement.

BATTLE STAR

This Battle Star may use the **Lucky** ability seven times in this scenario:

- **Lucky:** Each use of **Lucky** allows a player to reroll an Attack Roll once per scenario. The second result stands, even if it fails or is worse than the first. This ability may not be used to change the outcome of other types of rolls such as critical hit checks or Initiative. (If using the Multiple Attack Rolls optional rule, each use of **Lucky** allows all Attack Rolls for an attack to be rerolled. If used, all the Attack Rolls must be rerolled, and the second result stands for all of them.)

FORCE BUILDING

THE BATTLETECH MASTER UNIT LIST (MUL)

The BattleTech Master Unit List (MUL) at **www.MasterUnitList.info** is an online tool for use with *BattleTech* and *Alpha Strike* games.

This ever-growing (and free to use) database of official unit specs provides players with the means to build setting-accurate Forces by identifying the 'Mechs, vehicles, fighters, and infantry elements covered by the last thirty-five years of *Technical Readout* sourcebooks and other publications. While the database can be used with this box set, it pairs wonderfully with the *Alpha Strike: Commander's Edition* rulebook

Players can browse their desired unit types by clicking "Units" and entering information into the various filter tabs. These filters include:

- Basic data (such as desired unit weight ranges, *BattleTech* Battle Values, years of in-universe introduction, costs in C-bills—the dominant unit of currency used in the *BattleTech* setting—and even *Alpha Strike* special ability codes);
- Technology bases (Inner Sphere, Clan, Mixed, and Primitive);
- *BattleTech* Rules levels (introductory, standard, advanced, and experimental);
- Unit Types (e.g. BattleMech, ProtoMech, Combat Vehicle, and so forth);
- Source (the most comprehensive and available source in which the unit appears, and the current *BattleTech* Record Sheet product for the unit);
- Factions (Clan Jade Falcon, Federated Suns, Draconis Combine, and more); Unit Sub-Types (such as VTOLs and OmniMechs);
- Production and Availability Eras (from the Age of War through the present ilClan era). Production Era filters the units to only include those that first produced in the Era. Availability Era filters the unit to only show units with at least one faction availability listed for that Era.

The list of units returned via these filters provides names and variants/configurations of each unit, its tonnage (mass), Battle Value, cost (in C-bills), the title of the primary sourcebook in which the unit is described, the unit's rules level, the era in which the unit came into general use, and the unit's intro year (the specific in-universe point in which the selected unit debuted). By clicking on the names of a listed unit, the user can then view more distinct stats for it, including—at the very bottom of the page—links to images of these units courtesy of CamoSpecs Online (www.camospecs.com), another partner site, and, if available, an *Alpha Strike* card for the model and variant selected. These *Alpha Strike* cards may be copied, customized, and printed.

Armed with this tool, players can access the broadest possible selection of playable *BattleTech* units, and begin building custom armies suitable for any desired period or faction in the official *BattleTech* canon.

Now that you've played both scenarios, these Force Building and Formations sections—in conjunction with the rules from Setup—will unlock the pleasure of building your own scenarios!

'Mechs are organized into Formations (Stars for Clans, lances for Inner Sphere) that together comprise the player's Force. Each 'Mech has a role which reflects that 'Mech's battlefield specialization. The player organizes their 'Mechs into Formations, each with a Formation Type reflecting its specialization.

Roles are the easiest guide to placing 'Mechs into Formation Types, but not the only way. The Formation Type may bestow bonus abilities to some or all of the 'Mechs which comprise the Formation. Each step is presented below.

STEP 1: SELECT FORCE SIZE

There are several methods for determining a Force size. Players should agree on the method and limits before beginning play.

Number of 'Mechs: Players may simply select a number of 'Mechs for each Force. This works best when both Forces have the same access to technology for their 'Mechs (for example, if both Forces are comprised of Clan 'Mechs). Players will also usually want to set requirements for each Force's Sizes. For example, the players may agree on a Force where the 'Mech Size attributes total no more than 11.

Point Value: Point Value (PV) is the more in-depth method of balancing Forces for *Alpha Strike*. Each 'Mech has a Point Value based on its movement capabilities, armor, weapons and ability to handle the heat from its equipment.

Mark decides to build a Star of 'Mechs with a maximum Point Value of 250. This should be enough for him to field Veteran MechWarriors piloting a mixed-weight Star of Clan OmniMechs.

STEP 2: CHOOSE ERA AND FACTION

After selecting a Force size, the next step is to determine setting details for the scenario or campaign in which the Force will fight—particularly the era of play, and the faction in which the Force will serve. These details may not seem terribly important for players interested in a simple pick-up game, but *BattleTech* is home

to thousands of different units as well as ever-evolving technologies which developed over hundreds of years of in-game history. Setting a campaign or even a one-shot scenario in a historical context helps to establish which factions, 'Mechs, and technologies are available to the Force, and provides a much more rich experience.

The 'Mechs and configurations provided in the *Alpha Strike* boxed set are well suited for the Clan Invasion era, but continued to be common in the Civil War era and well into the Jihad, Dark Age, and ilClan eras.

Mark would prefer to use the Alpha Strike *box set miniatures. And while he has several era options, including the Clan Invasion, he's just grabbed the* Empire Alone *sourcebook and is excited to delve into an ilClan era campaign.*

Using the Master Unit List, he reviews the unit page of each 'Mech. Under Faction Availability for the ilClan era, he sees most of the 'Mechs from the box set are common to all Invading Clans and all Homeworld Clans. Though this box presents Clan Jade Falcon vs. the Northwind Highlanders, he knows he has good options. Mark chooses Clan Wolf as the faction for his Force.

Mark now clicks on "Eras" in the main navigation bar of the Master Unit List, and then selects "ilClan." Lastly, he clicks on "Clan Wolf." The results are a comprehensive list of 'Mechs available for him to choose for his Force. From here he can view the 'Mechs' base Battle Values, and click on each one to examine additional details.

STEP 3: BUILD A FORMATION

Once a Force's factions and eras have been selected, players may begin organizing their Force by selecting Formations and filling them with 'Mechs and grabbing their respective unit cards.

The Formation Type will describe the general combat mission of the Formation and any bonus abilities it earns as a result of its Type



(see *Formations*, p. 37). Additionally, Formations must consist of at least three 'Mechs to receive any bonus abilities. The 'Mechs included in a Formation must fulfill the requirements for that Formation Type to receive the bonus abilities listed.

STEP 4: SELECT SKILLS

Select each 'Mech's Skill rating. Players should agree beforehand on any minimum or maximum Skill ratings allowed in play.

A 'Mech's Point Value is modified for the Skill of its MechWarrior. Each 'Mech's base Point Value assumes a Skill rating of 4. Lower Skill ratings increase a 'Mech's Point Value. How many points this Skill rating decrease will increase the 'Mech's PV is based on the 'Mech's base PV with a "default" Skill rating of 4. For 'Mechs with a Skill rating lower than 4, the PV of a 'Mech is increased by 1 point per point of Skill rating increase if the 'Mech's base PV is 1 to 7 points, with an

*Mark looks up the Unit Roles of the configurations of each of the box set OmniMechs; one side of the Unit Card with Era Availability icons that cover back to the Succession Wars, and the other focused on configurations available in the Dark Age and ilClan eras. Looking at the most modern configurations, he sees a Scout (*Pouncer *T), a Striker (*Fire Moth *G), Skirmisher (*Nova *T), a Missile Boat (*Timber Wolf *T) and Brawler (*Warhawk *T). Fortunately for Mark, Clan OmniMechs' various configurations give them a wide range of possible Formation Types they can fit into, but their Primary Role can be helpful in suggesting a Formation.*

Strikers and Skirmishers work well with Striker/Cavalry Stars; Missile Boats with Fire Stars; and Brawlers and Skirmishers with Battle Stars. Despite that flexibility, Mark chooses the Command Star as a good, general purpose combat Formation.

For a moment, Mark considers a Fire Star, but he would need two additional 'Mechs in a Sniper or Missile Boat configuration. Mark returns to the Master Unit List and clicks on "Units." Then, on the filters panel on the left, he clicks on "Alpha Strike" and selects "Missile Boat" from the "Role" pull-down menu. Next, he clicks on "Factions," types Clan Wolf, and selects it in the text box. Lastly, he opens the "Availability Era" panel and checks "ilClan."

Once Mark is happy with all the search filters he's selected, he clicks on the "Filter" button at the bottom, which results in a list of all Missile Boat-role 'Mechs which are available to Mark's faction during the era chosen for his Force. Not seeing anything he likes more, Mark decides to stick with the Command Star as his Formation.

Mark looks at the Timber Wolf *T as his Force's first 'Mech. The base Point Value listed on the unit card and on the Master Unit List for this 'Mech is 63. Mark wants the* Timber Wolf *to have an Elite MechWarrior, so he assigns a 2 Skill to the 'Mech. Searching on the Master Unit List for the* Timber Wolf *T, he clicks the orange + button next to the search results or the +Force button on 'Mech's page. When Mark uses the Force menu option and selects Alpha Strike Builder, he will see his 'Mech in the list for his Force, and a dropdown selector for Skill rating. As he selects different Skill ratings for his 'Mech, the PV column will show the Skill-adjusted PV and a total row showing the total Skill-adjusted PV of the Force Mark has selected.*

Mark repeats these steps for each of his 'Mechs, selecting Skill ratings for each MechWarrior and noting the adjusted Point Value. If necessary, he can adjust these ratings to create a Force that remains under his maximum Point Value of 250.

IMPROVED SKILL PV INCREASE TABLE

'Mech's Base PV	PV Increase per Rating
0–7	1
8–12	2
13–17	3
18–22	4
23–27	5
28–32	6
33–37	7
38–42	8
43–47	9
48–52	10*

* Increase PV by 1 point for every 5 base PV over 52.

additional increase of 1 more point (per point of Skill rating increase) for every 5 base PV the 'Mech is worth after that. For ease of reference, this formula is translated into the Improved Skill PV Increase Table.

For example, a 'Mech with a base PV of 39 at a Skill rating of 4, when assigned a MechWarrior of Skill 2, would increase its PV cost by 16 points (8 [PV increase for a 'Mech of 38–42 base PV] x 2 [2 Skill Rating decreases below Skill 4] = 16). This increases the 'Mech's PV to 55 (39 + 16 = 55). (The Master Unit List also shows the revised Point Value calculation for Skill ratings for *Alpha Strike* units.)

Default Values: The default Skill for Inner Sphere MechWarriors is 4, and the default Skill for Clan MechWarriors is 3. Even if using the default Clan Skill rating, the increased Point Value amount from the Skill rating improvement must be paid.

UNIT ROLE

A Unit Role is the primary intended use of a 'Mech on a battlefield. While most 'Mechs can be used for nearly any role if necessary, each 'Mech is limited to a single primary role that it is most effective at accomplishing. If all you have is an *Atlas*, you can scout with it, but you overpaid for a scout. The Unit Role is assigned based on what the 'Mech is intended for, or the role in which it is most used.

Most Unit Roles for 'Mechs are based on three questions: is the 'Mech meant to be constantly moving, how tough is it, and at what range does it prefer to fight?

In addition to these building rules, Unit Roles can be used as guidelines for how you'd actually deploy and use them during a scenario.

Unit Card: Alpha Strike Unit Cards have the Unit Role printed on them, while players can also find all Unit Roles on the MUL.

BRAWLER

Brawlers are line 'Mechs, commonly deployed among Battle lances and Stars. They are fast enough to keep up with a "standard" line, have at least adequate armor, and possess flexibility with range requirements; they are usually able to do some damage at longer ranges but deliver increasing damage as they close range with a target. They should not have to pull out of line to enter combat, but are able to hold the line if it is charged. The *Timber Wolf* Prime, BJ-3 *Blackjack,* WHM-6R/8R *Warhammer*, and *Warhawk* T are examples of Brawlers.

JUGGERNAUT

Juggernauts are slow, very tough 'Mechs that prefer close combat. Juggernauts control their immediate terrain—the difficulty is often in getting them where they need to be. Juggernauts are useful for holding or taking territory, but can be a liability during running battles in which there is no clear territory to control. The AS7-S *Atlas* is an example of a Juggernaut.

SNIPER

Snipers prefer to find a good "sniper's nest," sit still and fire at long range. Some Snipers rely on range, stealth or cover for defense, while others rely on armor. Few rely on speed, as this often is detrimental to their own ability to hit at long range. Though some that are meant to provide fire support to faster 'Mechs may have enough speed to keep up with them. The *Warhawk* C, BJ-5 *Blackjack*, *Pouncer* Prime, and AS7-S4 *Atlas* are examples of Snipers.

MISSILE BOAT

Missile Boats are similar to Snipers, but the majority of their long range damage comes from weapons capable of indirect fire, such as long range missiles. Missile Boats are often grouped together in order to optimize their ability to fire indirectly, without rendering part of their Formation as incapable of firing. The ARC-5R/7C *Archer* and *Timber Wolf* T are examples of Missile Boats.

STRIKER

Strikers are fast, possess light armor, and usually prefer short or medium range engagements. They rely on their speed (or numbers) to survive while threatening the rear or flanks of the enemy. The PXH-3k/4M *Phoenix Hawk* and *Fire Moth* D/G are examples of Strikers.

SKIRMISHER

Skirmishers are fast, but boast adequate or even heavy armor. The flexibility to rely on speed or armor for defense can give Skirmishers the ability to withstand a great deal of incoming fire, but they usually prefer not to have to sit still to hold an objective or deliver accurate fire. Skirmishers often command lighter Strikers, provide a flanking threat alongside slower Brawlers or Juggernauts, or are massed with other Skirmishers as heavy cavalry formations. The TR1/TR5 *Wraith* and *Nova* Prime/T are examples of Skirmishers.

SCOUT

Scouts are fast, equipped with light (or no armor) and very little weaponry. In eras when high-end or recovered technology is available, they often employ advanced electronics as well. The Scout is forced into combat only by necessity, preferring to serve as a spotter or support for other 'Mechs in the Force. The WSP-3W/5A *Wasp*, LCT-3M/7V *Locust*, and *Pouncer* T are examples of Scouts.

CLAN ORGANIZATION

The basic organization of Clan *toumans* are Stars, each made up of five Points. A Point is a single BattleMech. Combining two Stars creates a Binary, while three Stars forms a Trinary.

The Clans combine three to five Binaries or Trinaries into Clusters. Clusters are commonly assigned to achieve strategic objectives, with bidding often taking place between Clusters to determine which Cluster gets the honor of the assignment.

The largest formation within a Clan *touman* is the Galaxy, composed of three to five Clusters. Galaxies are commanded by a Galaxy Commander, with a Clan's most prestigious Galaxies often led by the Loremaster, saKhan or even the Khan. Full Galaxies are deployed only for the most significant engagements.

A Clan's entire military might is known as that Clan's *touman*.

CLAN FORCE ORGANIZATION SCHEMES TABLE

Organization	Definition	Command Rank
Point ('Mech)	1 'Mech	MechWarrior or Point Commander
Star	5 Points	Star Commander
Binary	2 Stars	Star Captain
Trinary	3 Stars	Star Captain
Cluster	3–5 Binaries or Trinaries	Star Colonel
Galaxy	3–5 Clusters	Galaxy Commander
Touman	3–12 Galaxies	Khan

INNER SPHERE ORGANIZATION

The basic organization of Inner Sphere militaries are lances, made up of four BattleMechs. Combining three to four lances creates a company. Three to four companies combine into battalions, while three to four battalions in turn comprise a regiment.

The largest formation fielded by the Great Houses today is the brigade, which is led by a general and composed of three to six regiments with a shared heritage and naming scheme. Since the fall of the Star League, it is all but unheard of for an entire brigade to be involved in a single battle.

INNER SPHERE ORGANIZATION SCHEMES TABLE

Organization	Definition	Command Rank
Lance	4 'Mechs	Lieutenant
Company	3–4 Lances	Captain
Battalion	3–4 companies	Major
Regiment	3–4 battalions	Colonel
Brigade	3–4 regiments	General



FORMATIONS

A Force's component Stars or lances can be assembled using only the organization schemes described in the previous section. The various militaries of the *BattleTech* universe, however, often prefer to build their Formations around specific Unit Roles to maximize their effectiveness in battle.

To represent this, the Formation Types in this section define the various types of mission-based Stars and lances in common use, along with their requirements and benefits. These Formation Types draw on the unique Unit Roles of the various 'Mechs available in *BattleTech* play to create special battlefield advantages for players choosing to use them.

FORMATION REQUIREMENTS

Each of the Formation Types presented in this chapter lists requirements to qualify as a Formation of that type and receive the related bonus abilities: a specific ratio or number of 'Mech Sizes, Unit Roles, movement capabilities, and so forth.

If a Formation Type lists a requirement as a percentage, this requirement applies equally to four-'Mech lances and five-'Mech Stars, meaning the number of 'Mechs represented by this percentage value may need to be rounded up as necessary. For example, the requirements for a Battle Lance indicate that 50 percent of the Formation must be Size 3 or greater. In a four-'Mech Inner Sphere lance, that translates to two 'Mechs of Size 3 or more (4 x 0.5 = 2). For the Clan equivalent—a Battle Star—this requirement increases to three 'Mechs (5 x 0.5 = 2.5, rounded up to 3).

Formation Types do not "stack," even if the 'Mechs assigned to a Formation would fit the criteria for multiple Formation Types. For instance, the requirements for the Assault Star also satisfy the less restrictive criteria of the Battle Star, but the player creating the Force must designate the Formation as one or the other.

IDEAL ROLE

Some—but not all—Formations may list an "ideal role" in their descriptions. Ideal roles refer to Unit Roles as defined in the previous section, and serve as a special loophole to any other Formation requirements. If all of a Formation's 'Mechs possess the same Unit Role indicated by the Formation Type's ideal role entry, the Formation Type's requirements are considered met, even if they might otherwise not be.

For example, the ideal role for a Battle Star is that of the Brawler. Because of this, the Star's standard requirement that 50 percent of its 'Mechs must be Size 3 or greater is waived if all five 'Mechs in that Star have the Brawler Unit Role.

BONUS ABILITIES

Each Formation Type offers at least one bonus ability, which reflects the cooperative tactics and complementary weapons and equipment the Formation gains due to its composition. A 'Mech benefits from its bonus ability as long as three of its 'Mechs are not destroyed. Each bonus ability is detailed in an accompanying text box.

NAMING CONVENTIONS

Players may wish to name their Formations to give them more character. In the *BattleTech* universe, naming conventions for small Formations tend to vary quite wildly. They may be named for their role (e.g., "Recon Star"), for the Formation's commander (e.g., "Roscoe's Lance"), identified by simple phonetic alphabet or numeric designators (e.g., "Bravo Second Star"), their weight class (e.g., "Medium Lance"), or by faction-specific nomenclature that can border on the esoteric (e.g., "Alpha Talon 2").

For the purposes of game play, any name given to a Star or lance is secondary to the Formation Type, which must be recorded during the Force-building process. Thus, even if the player has named their Force's Assault Star "Schmidt's Savages," they must still identify that the Formation was built as an Assault Star.

FORMATION TYPES

ASSAULT LANCE / STAR

Assault Formations are the powerhouses of any Force. Making up for their reduced speed with massive firepower and armor, these Formations rely on brute force to smash their way toward the enemy and demolish all that they find.

Requirements: At least three 'Mechs in this Formation must be Size 3 or greater, and there can be no Size 1 'Mechs in this Formation Type. All 'Mechs in an Assault Formation must have at least 5 Armor, and at least 75 percent of the 'Mechs in this Formation must possess a Medium-range damage value of 3 or more.

An Assault Formation must contain at least one 'Mech of the Juggernaut Unit Role, or 2 'Mechs of the Sniper Unit Role.

Ideal Role: Juggernaut

Bonus Ability: At the beginning of each game turn, the player may designate up to two 'Mechs in the Formation to receive the **Demoralizer** ability (see p. 38) for the duration of the turn.

BATTLE LANCE / STAR

Battle Formations are the "line" troops of any Force. Whether holding the center of a combat group or supporting a reinforced assault, the Battle Formation is meant to close range with the enemy, relying on armor and mass to sustain its 'Mechs while their heavy firepower pummels the enemy.

Common Battle Formations often grouped by their 'Mechs' weight classes. These weight-specific Formations usually drop the word "Battle" from their nomenclature and are frequently referred to by generic-sounding terms like "Heavy Star" or "Medium lance."

Requirements: 50 percent of the standard Battle Formation must be Size 3 or greater. At least three 'Mechs in this Formation must also possess any combination of the Brawler, Sniper and/or Skirmisher Unit Roles.

Ideal Role: Brawler

COMBAT INTUITION

"I hate it when I am right..."

The MechWarrior with this ability has a knack for accurately predicting an enemy's actions. Though this intuition is not quite powerful enough to pass along to an entire force before the enemy has time to react, the warrior can make use of their insight to cut off a single opponent once in a while.

If this 'Mech's side wins Initiative, the 'Mech whose MechWarrior has this ability can move and resolve all of its attacks during the Movement Phase, applying all damage effects immediately—before any target 'Mechs can act. This ability can only be used once every 3 turns.

DEMORALIZER

"Come and face me, little Spheroid—if you dare!"

A MechWarrior with the Demoralizer ability can make their 'Mech a holy terror on the battlefield, projecting an intimidating presence that seems to manifest in the way they operate their machine and taunts their enemy (with or without the use of communications equipment).

During the Combat Phase, the player can select one enemy unit within line of sight and medium range of this unit to try to intimidate. The Demoralizer unit must make a 2D6 roll, with a target number of 8 + the Demoralizer's Skill – the Demoralizer's SZ. Success intimidates the target.

Units that are Intimidated in this fashion subtract 2" from their MV and 1 from their TMM, to a minimum of 2" MV and 0 TMM, and suffer a +1 Target Number modifier to all attacks made against the intimidating unit. The intimidation takes effect in the End Phase of this turn and lasts through the End Phase of the next turn.

LUCKY

"I close my eyes, listen to the hum of the thermal imager, and FIRE!"

Each use of Lucky allows a 'Mech in the Formation to reroll an Attack Roll once per scenario. The second result stands, even if it fails or is worse than the first. This ability may not be used to change the outcome of other types of rolls such as critical hit checks or Initiative.

If using the Multiple Attack Rolls optional rule (see p. 21), each use of Lucky allows all Attack Rolls for an attack to be rerolled. If used, all the Attack Rolls must be rerolled, and the second result stands for all of them.

MANEUVERING ACE

"My call sign is not Drifter because I wander from place to place..."

MechWarriors with the Maneuvering Ace Ability are especially good at executing quick turns and maneuvering in tight confines.

This 'Mech reduces the cost for moving through all woods and jungle terrain types by 1 inch per inch of movement.

SNIPER

"I can ruin a trachazoi's sex life at a quarter-klick."

The Sniper ability reduces all weapon attack Target Number modifiers due to range by half; attacks apply a +1 Target Number modifier at Medium Range (rather than +2), and a +2 Target Number modifier at Long Range (rather than +4).

SPEED DEMON

"Speed is life...and fun!"

A MechWarrior with the Speed Demon ability can really pour it on! The 'Mech receives an additional 2 inches of Move per turn when driven by a MechWarrior with this ability.

Bonus Ability: This Formation receives a number of uses of the **Lucky** ability equal to two plus the starting number of 'Mechs in this Formation.

COMMAND LANCE / STAR

As the name suggests, the Command Formation is built around the Force's commander (or their key sub-commanders). As such, this Formation is typically filled with a diverse group of capabilities intended to both support and protect their leader on the battlefield.

Requirements: At least one 'Mech in this Formation must be designated as the Command 'Mech. 50 percent of the 'Mechs must have one of the following Unit Roles: Sniper, Missile Boat, Skirmisher or Juggernaut. One additional 'Mech in the Formation must be a Brawler, Striker, or Scout. The 'Mech designated as the Command 'Mech may be any of the Formation's members, including these prerequisite 'Mechs.

Ideal Role: None

Bonus Ability: Prior to the beginning of play, two of the 'Mechs in this Formation—which cannot be the Command 'Mech—receive the **Combat Intuition** ability (see at left). This assignment cannot be changed once play begins.

In addition, if a Force possesses a Command Formation and the Command 'Mech is not destroyed, its controlling player may reroll Initiative Rolls once every two turns. However, this second roll stands, even if it fails or is worse than the first.

FIRE LANCE / STAR

Fire Formations carry powerful, long-range weaponry which enables them to stay far away from enemy forces and rain down devastating fire with less risk of being attacked themselves.

Requirements: At least 75 percent of the 'Mechs in this Formation must possess either the Missile Boat or Sniper Unit Roles.

Ideal Role: Missile Boat



Bonus Ability: At the beginning of each turn, up to two Fire Formation 'Mechs may receive the **Sniper** ability (see sidebar, p. 38), which will affect their weapon attacks during that turn.

RECON LANCE/STAR

Recon Formations employ extremely fast 'Mechs that can rush ahead of the main force, using their speed to scout objectives, evade enemy fire, and harass or flank their opponents. This Formation Type is particularly useful in campaign settings where intelligence gathering is important but can also be helpful in standard scenarios.

Requirements: All 'Mechs in a Recon Formation must possess a minimum Move of 10". At least two 'Mechs in this Formation must also possess the Scout or Striker Unit Roles.

Ideal Role: Scout

Bonus Ability: All members of the Recon Formation receive the **Maneuvering Ace** ability (see sidebar, p. 38).

STRIKER/CAVALRY LANCE/STAR

Striker Formations (also known as Cavalry Formations) are made up of fast-moving 'Mechs that can quickly bring their firepower into combat, while also possessing enough armor to survive an engagement and withdraw or to hold the line long enough for the main force to arrive.

Requirements: All 'Mechs in a Striker/Cavalry Formation must have a minimum Move of 10" or a jumping movement of 8"j or more. No 'Mechs in a Striker/Cavalry Formation may be Size 4.

At least 50 percent of the Striker/Cavalry Star must possess the Striker or Skirmisher Unit Roles.

Ideal Role: Striker

Bonus Ability: Prior to the beginning of play, assign three of the 'Mechs in the Striker/Cavalry Formation the **Speed Demon** ability (see sidebar, p. 38).

SUPPORT LANCE/STAR

These are multi-role Formations that do not actually excel at any one job, but instead exist mainly to back up other Formations.

Requirements: None

Ideal Role: None

Bonus Ability: Before the start of play, each Support Formation must designate one other Formation in its Force to support. For every two 'Mechs in the supported Formation that receive an ability from their Formation Type, one 'Mech in its Support Formation receives the same ability. This bonus ability is retained as long as the Support Formation still has three or more 'Mechs that are not destroyed; it is not lost if the supported Formation is reduced in number and loses its own bonus ability.

If the Support Formation is supporting a Command Formation, it receives the two **Combat Intuition** (see sidebar, p. 38) abilities assigned to the Command Formation's non-Command 'Mechs. However, the Support Formation does not receive the commander's Initiative reroll ability. If the Support Formation is supporting a Battle Formation, the Support Formation gets half (round up) the uses of the **Lucky** ability.

BATTLETECH™



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